

Servant and Seal

The Qur'anic Portraiture of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ Between Exaltation and Accountability

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The Qur'an's address to the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ moves across a graded register, from the exaltation of his office to the insistence on his created humanity, and the same sūra that raises him to a cosmic station will often return him, within a few verses, to the condition of a mortal under judgment. At the summit he is the mercy to the worlds, the seal of prophecy, the one upon whom God and the angels invoke blessing, and the bearer of names that are elsewhere the names of God. At the same time he is told that he is only a human being, that he holds no knowledge of the unseen, that he commands no power over outcomes, and he is reproved for particular acts and commanded to seek forgiveness. This study treats the two reaches as a single motif and argues that the portrait is internally coherent. Two features unify it. First, the Qur'an locates the source of the Prophet's ﷺ authority outside himself at every turn, so that his greatness is a greatness of reception and conveyance rather than of autonomous origin; the point reaches its limit where his own act is named the act of God, the throw that is God's throwing and the hand pledged to him that is the hand of God. Second, the reproaches and the commands to seek forgiveness do not compete with his rank but constitute it, on the model of the Qur'an's own Adam, whom his Lord chose after he had erred and turned back (20:121-122). A further register sets his endowment beside that of the earlier prophets: where Moses was given the staff and the parted sea and Jesus the healing breath and the titles of Word and Spirit, the sign of the Prophet ﷺ is the recited Book, and he is presented as the one they foretold and as the seal, in the sense the noun *khātam* carries of the certifying and completing mark rather than the bare terminus, set upon their line. Its coverage is weighted by a principle of distribution rather than concentration: the register of elevation is the best-served in the existing literature and is not enlarged here, and the weighting falls chiefly across the three movements, eleven of whose twenty themes stand wholly outside that register, rather than within the nine-fold grid, where the measured loading of the three columns is closer than that description would imply and is given in the introduction. The paper proceeds in three movements: nine themes that draw the portrait, each in a three-part table of elevation, neutral, and warning; four that read it contested, the charge that he fabricated the revelation, the demand that he produce spectacle, and the refusal of the People of the Book who had awaited him, answered from the same text and traced to one root, envy after knowledge; and seven that read the servant under trial, the slander and the law awaited and the bounded knowledge and the frown and the firmness and the unseen audience and the hidden enemy and his own vulnerability, in each of which the resolution descends from God and not from him. Throughout it reads the principal terms at the level of their triliteral roots, illuminated where a sense is not plain by the same root's use elsewhere, taking the Qur'an as its governing source and interpreting it by its own usage. It concludes that veneration and accountability in the Qur'anic portrait of the Prophet ﷺ are two faces of one theology of the servant-prophet. Read to its end, that same servanthood turns the portrait outward: the seal upon the prophets, taken in the sense its noun carries of the mark that ratifies and completes rather than the mark that merely ends, closes the office of revelation, on a reading that does not depend on how the offices of prophet and messenger are related to one another, while leaving open the road of the servant the prophets exemplify and the trials make concrete, the road the Prophet ﷺ himself walked by turning to God in every crisis, and whose very protection, the refuge of the closing sūras, is a word given to every believer alike;

and the study closes by reading that road as the text leaves it, a path held open to whoever will walk it and an invitation rather than a wall.

KEYWORDS Qur'an; prophetology; Muhammad ﷺ; khatam al-nabiyyin; 'itab al-nabi; servanthood; root analysis; comparative prophecy

1. Introduction

The Qur'an does not address the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in a single voice. Across the text he is named, described, and spoken to along a spectrum that runs from the exaltation of his office to the affirmation of his created humanity. At one pole stand the titles that gather the highest honor. He is the mercy sent to all the worlds, the seal who closes the line of prophecy, a lamp that gives light, the one upon whom God and the angels themselves invoke blessing, and he is named with words that the Qur'an elsewhere reserves for its Lord. At the other pole stand the verses that strip every such elevation back to its created ground. He is told to announce that he is only a human being, that he holds no knowledge of the unseen, that he commands no power to benefit or harm even himself, that he will die as those before him died. Between these poles the Qur'an also speaks of him in a plain functional register, as a warner and a bringer of good news, a man among the people to whom he is sent.

The upper reach of this spectrum became, across the centuries, the material of devotion, elaborated in praise. The lower reach is no less present in the text. The emphasis on the Prophet's ﷺ humanity, his *bashariyya*, recurs throughout, and the verses that reprove him are direct and numerous enough that the tradition gathered them under a name, the reproaches of the Prophet, *'itab al-nabi*. The two reaches are usually read apart, the one as honor and the other as a difficulty to be managed. This study reads them together, as one motif, and it reads the Qur'an by the Qur'an. The text supplies its own frame for holding exaltation and accountability in a single hand, and that frame is followed here rather than any imported one.

The thesis is that the portrait coheres, and that it coheres through two features of the text. The first is that the Qur'an locates the source of the Prophet's ﷺ authority outside himself at every turn. His very name, Muḥammad, is a passive form from the root *ḥ-m-d*, to praise: he is the one who is praised, not the one who praises, and the praise flows to him from a higher source that bears the same root. He is *rasūl*, from *r-s-l*, the one sent, dispatched by a sender. He is *'abd*, from *'b-d*, the servant, the title the Qur'an chooses for him at the height of his ascent. His greatness, read at the root, is everywhere a greatness of reception and conveyance, never of an autonomous origin he carries in himself. The point reaches its sharpest expression, examined in Sections 6 and 23, in the verses where his own act is named the act of God: of the throw at the battle of Badr, "you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17), and of the pledge of allegiance sworn to him, "the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10).

The second feature concerns the reproaches. The Qur'an's commands to the Prophet ﷺ to seek forgiveness, and its direct corrections of his conduct, do not sit in tension with his standing. They instantiate it.

The controlling paradigm is the Qur'an's own account of Adam, who errs and is chosen after the erring: "and Adam disobeyed his Lord and went astray; then his Lord chose him, and turned to him, and guided" (20:121-122). The election follows the fault and the turning, in that order and in one sentence, and the contrast the text draws is with the party that errs and pleads an inherent superiority instead of returning (7:12). The honoring of Adam before the angels is a separate matter and rests on other ground, the teaching of the names (2:31-34), and it is not claimed here as the ground of this paradigm. On this logic the Prophet's ﷺ corrigibility is not a subtraction from his rank but its mechanism, and the Qur'an marks the point by issuing the command to seek forgiveness at the very summit of his victory.

To this point the portrait is the one the Qur'an draws of him. The text also preserves the portrait as it was contested, and the second movement of the study reads that record. His hearers could not agree what he was, calling him poet and sorcerer and madman and forger; they prescribed the spectacle a messenger must bring, a visible God, a book from the sky, an angel at his side; and the People of the Book, who had awaited him and knew him, refused him when he came because the grace had fallen outside their lineage. The Qur'an answers each contest from the same text and then names its single root. The rejection of the prophets, the demand for wonders, the envy of the chosen, and at the last the fracturing of the one religion into sects, are traced to one cause, *baghy*, the envy that resents a gift given to another, and the diagnosis is turned, in the end, upon the believers themselves.

The text met him not only as drawn and as contested but as tried. The third movement reads the crises of his life: the slander against his house, the woman whose plea he could not answer, the questions that probed the limit of his knowledge, the frown he was reproved for and the firmness he was held by, the unseen audience and the staked confrontation, the hidden enemy and the law of the struggle, and his own vulnerability to harm. In every one the resolution descends from God and is not produced by him, and the trials return, under fire, the finding the portrait had drawn at rest: that his greatness is a greatness of reception, and that what he is given he does not generate.

These features, traced through the registers of all three movements and gathered in the synthesis, open of themselves onto a further question, and the study takes it up in Section 24 before the conclusion. The highest of the Prophet's ﷺ titles is *khātam*, the seal, and once that noun is read in the sense its own form carries, the mark that ratifies and completes rather than the mark that merely ends, the portrait raises of itself the question of what that seal closes and what it leaves open, and of what a portrait of the servant-prophet, so read, holds out to the one who comes to it. The portrait and the contest

brought against it are set out first; the question they raise is answered last, from the same text and by the same method.

A word on method and sources. This study foregrounds the Qur'anic text in its plain semantic and lexical sense, reading the triliteral roots that carry the meaning directly from the Arabic, following a key root through its other occurrences where its sense in a given verse is not plain, and interpreting the Qur'an by its own usage. Where the text attributes a fault or issues a correction, the fault and the correction are presented as the text gives them, without recourse to the later doctrinal harmonizations that sought to soften them. A word is owed on how the three registers are weighted, since the weighting is deliberate and a reader may otherwise take it for a gap. The register of elevation is the best-served in the existing literature by a wide margin; the great titles have been gathered, expounded, and set to verse for centuries, and this study does not add to a shelf already full. Its coverage is therefore weighted toward the registers that are under-read, and its principle is distribution rather than concentration. The size of that weighting is checkable against the tables and is better stated than left to impression. It operates chiefly across the movements: eleven of the twenty themes, the four of the contest and the seven of the trial, stand wholly outside the register of elevation. Within the nine tables of the first movement the three columns are more evenly loaded than a rhetoric of weighting would suggest, the column of warning carrying fifty-nine cited verses against the elevation column's forty-seven and the neutral column's thirty-four. Elevation is therefore not thin in these tables; it is simply not enlarged, entering where it is needed to hold the grid, to establish a register, or to carry a structural point that the grounding verses answer, rather than for its own sake. The study is structural rather than devotional throughout, and it is that fixed register, settled before the first table, which allows the corrective verses to be carried at full strength with nothing to soften and nothing to apologize for. The evidence is the Qur'an itself, cited by sūra and verse; English wording has been checked against the standard translations listed in the Sources, and the renderings given here are the author's own. The historical occasions reported in the biographical literature are noted only where the text itself requires a setting, and the analysis does not depend on them. One convention follows from that and is stated once here rather than repeated: where this study uses a name or a setting the Qur'an does not carry, it is the reported occasion serving as shorthand and never as evidence. Uḥud, Najrān, Zaynab, and 'Ā'isha are of that kind and are named nowhere in the text; the hearers called Meccans are "among us" in the verse (38:8); Badr, by contrast, the Qur'an does name (3:123). The point is worth making sharply, since it is the study's own thesis in miniature: of all the companions the Qur'an names exactly one, Zayd at 33:37, and it names him in the verse that severs adoption from sonship, where the naming serves the law and not the man.

The body falls into three movements. The first proceeds through nine themes of the portrait, each table marking how the same theme appears under elevation, under a neutral or functional treatment, and under warning and accountability. The second proceeds through four themes of the portrait contested, each table marking the contention raised, the response the text makes, and the verdict it reaches. The

third proceeds through seven themes of the servant under trial, each table marking the trial faced, the divine response sent down, and the resolution it works. A short discussion precedes every table, and each table closes with the principal term and its root. Section 2 defines the three registers of the first movement before the analysis begins.

2. The Three Registers of Address

The columns that organize the tables below name three registers in which the Qur'an speaks of the Prophet ﷺ. They are analytic categories, drawn to make the motif legible, and the text does not always observe their borders cleanly. The word *register* is reserved in this study for these three and for them alone; the twenty units of the body are called themes throughout, and where a theme is spoken of as a register of address the three columns are meant and not the theme. A single term can carry more than one charge at once, as the discussion of *'abd* in Section 3 and of the throw at Badr in Section 6 will show. With that caution the three registers may be defined as follows.

The register of **elevation** gathers the titles and statements that raise the Prophet's ﷺ office to a cosmic or salvific dimension. It includes the great honorific names, the affirmations of his terminal and universal place, the declarations that bind obedience to him to obedience to God, and the marks of singular divine favor toward his person: the protection from his enemies, the consolation offered in his distress, the oath sworn by his life, the reorientation of the qibla to his unspoken wish, the abundance granted after his loss. These are read here as elevation because they single him out as the object of a care and a station granted to no one else, even though their grammar, examined closely, keeps the favor on the side of the Giver.

The register of **neutral** or functional address gathers the designations that state the Prophet's ﷺ role without exalting or diminishing it, together with the plainly descriptive statements of his humanity, the regulation of his daily and domestic life, and the ethical instruction directed to him as it would be to any believer. Here he is the warner, the bringer of good news, the reciter of what is sent down, a man from among the people. The dominant grammatical form in this register is the imperative *qul*, "say," which introduces his speech hundreds of times and frames his office as the conveyance of a received word.

The register of **warning, accountability, and criticism** gathers the verses that fix the Prophet ﷺ as a created and accountable mortal. It includes the categorical statements of his humanity, the limits set on his power and his knowledge and his agency, the exposure of his fear and his grief, the direct reproaches, the explicit attribution of fault with the commands to seek forgiveness, the conditional threats of the severest kind, the warnings of betrayal he cannot himself detect, and the deficits noted in comparison with earlier prophets. This is the register in which the Qur'an most plainly portrays the Prophet ﷺ in a manner that is corrective or limiting, and the present study reports those portrayals directly rather than dissolving them. It is also, for the reason given in the introduction, the register this study covers most fully. The three columns are three positions on one contour rather

than three equal shares of attention, and the contour is read by walking the side that is least walked; their measured loading, given in the introduction, is closer than that description alone would imply, and the weighting of this study falls chiefly across its three movements rather than within this grid.

3. Theme One: Naming and Designation

The Qur'an's names for the Prophet ﷺ array themselves across all three registers, and the array is itself instructive. At the summit are the cosmic titles. He is *Khātam al-Nabiyyīn*, the Seal of the Prophets, the one in whom the prophetic succession is confirmed and brought to its completion (33:40), a title examined at its root in Section 10. He is *raḥmatan lil-‘ālamīn*, a mercy to the worlds, sent as mercy rather than merely bringing it (21:107). He is a radiant lamp, *sirājūn munīran* (33:46). The honor rises higher still. God Himself, with the angels, invokes blessing upon him: “God and His angels send blessings upon the Prophet” (33:56), and his very renown is lifted, “and We raised high for you your remembrance” (94:4). He is named, moreover, with words the Qur'an elsewhere reserves for its Lord: “to the believers most kind and most merciful,” *bi-l-mu'minīna ra'ūfun raḥīm* (9:128), where *ra'ūf* and *raḥīm* are two of the divine attributes, here predicated of the Prophet ﷺ. The two proper names sit on a single root. Muḥammad and Aḥmad both derive from *ḥ-m-d*, to praise, the first an intensive passive participle, the one repeatedly praised, the second an elative, most worthy of praise, placed in the Qur'an in the mouth of Jesus as a prophecy (61:6). Read at the root, the names are receptive. They mark him as the recipient of praise, not its origin.

In the neutral register stand the functional designations that name what he does. He is *al-Nabī*, the Prophet, and *al-Rasūl*, the Messenger, the sent one carrying a message. He is *bashīr wa nadhbīr*, a bringer of good news and a warner (2:119; 34:28). One structural feature of the address belongs here and is easily missed. Many of the

prophets named in the Qur'an are at some point called by their personal names in direct address, Adam, Noah, Abraham, Moses, Jesus, David among them, whether by God, by their peoples, or by their kin. The contrast is not universal, for several who are named are never so addressed at all, Idrīs and Dhū al-Kifl and al-Yasa' among these. Against those who are addressed by name, however, the observation holds without exception: the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is never once addressed as “O Muhammad.” To his face the Qur'an uses only the office, “O Prophet,” “O Messenger.” His personal name appears only in the third person, in statements about him. The veiling of the name behind the title is itself a form of honor, and it sits quietly within the otherwise plain functional register.

In the register of warning and grounding stand the designations that return him to his created condition. The most categorical is the command to declare his humanity: “Say: I am only a human being like you, to whom it is revealed” (18:110). The differentiating clause is the revelation, not the substance of the man, who is *basharun mithlukum*, human like his hearers. The same register includes the verse that spends his one proper name on a reminder of his mortality and his replaceability in function: “Muhammad is no more than a messenger; messengers have passed away before him” (3:144). And it includes the title *‘abd*, servant, which the text deploys at the very height of his experience, in the opening of the Night Journey: “Glory be to the One who took His servant by night” (17:1). Here the analytic borders blur, for *‘abd* is at once the mark of his nearness, the servant carried to the highest place, and the deepest grounding, the one who is owned and who serves. The ascent is named by the servitude. One further root binds the registers together. The word for his humanity, *bashar*, and the word for his function as herald, *bashīr*, share the root *b-sh-r*. The flesh that can be addressed as mortal and the office of bringing good news are spelled from the same three consonants.

Table 1 | Naming and Designation

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Titles raising his office to a cosmic and salvific dimension, including names elsewhere reserved for God.	Designations naming his prophetic function without exalting or diminishing it.	Names and declarations fixing him as a created, owned, and accountable mortal.
Context	Chiefly Medinan affirmations of his terminal and universal status, and of the honor God shows him.	Recurrent statements defining the mechanics of the mission.	Grounding statements, several set against demands to deify him.
Principal verses	al-Aḥzāb 33:40; al-Anbiyā’ 21:107; al-Tawba 9:128; al-Aḥzāb 33:56	al-Baqara 2:119; Saba’ 34:28	al-Kahf 18:110; Āl ‘Imrān 3:144; al-Isrā’ 17:1
Snippet	“the Messenger of God and the Seal of the Prophets” (33:40); “to the believers most kind and most merciful” (9:128); “God and His angels send blessings upon the Prophet” (33:56)	“We have sent you to all mankind only as a bringer of good news and a warner” (34:28)	“Say: I am only a human being like you, to whom it is revealed” (18:110); “Muhammad is no more than a messenger” (3:144)
Key term (root)	<i>khātām</i> (kh-t-m: to seal, certify, complete); <i>ra’ūf</i> (r-’-f: tender kindness); <i>raḥīm</i> (r-ḥ-m: womb, mercy)	<i>rasūl</i> (r-s-l: to send); <i>nadhīr</i> (n-dh-r: to warn)	<i>bashar</i> (b-sh-r: skin, flesh, humanity); <i>‘abd</i> (‘-b-d: to serve, worship)

4. Theme Two: Authority and Obedience

The elevation of the Prophet ﷺ authority is among the strongest in the Qur’an. Obedience to him is identified with obedience to God: “Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed God” (4:80). His judgment is made the test of faith itself, in an oath sworn by God on God’s own name: “But no, by your Lord, they will not believe until they make you judge in what is disputed between them, and then find no resistance within themselves to what you decide, and submit fully” (4:65). Once he and God have decided a matter, the believer retains no choice in it (33:36). What he gives is to be taken and what he forbids is to be left (59:7). And the claim runs deeper than command: “The Prophet has a greater claim on the believers than they have on their own selves” (33:6).

Even at this height, one feature of the grammar holds, and it should be stated exactly, since the looser form of it is not true. The Prophet ﷺ does stand alone as the grammatical subject of authority, and does so in three of the five verses just quoted: the claim on the believers is his at 33:6, the giving and forbidding are the Messenger’s at 59:7, and the judging is the addressee’s own at 4:65. What holds without exception is the pair of features that surround this. Wherever the two are named together the order is fixed and he is second, “God and His Messenger,” and the decree of 33:36 is “once God and His Messenger have decided,” with God first. And wherever he stands alone, the text refers the force beyond him in the same breath or in the verses that cap the office: obedience to him is obedience to God at 4:80, and what lies

upon him is the conveyance and no more at 5:99 and 24:54. The authority is his to exercise and is nowhere his to originate; the binding force is delegated. This is consistent with the wider pattern of the portrait, in which the Prophet ﷺ is the channel of an authority whose origin lies beyond him.

The neutral register defines the limit of his mandate at the point of delivery. He is a reminder and no more: “So remind; you are only a reminder” (88:21). His responsibility ends at conveyance: “The Messenger’s duty is only to convey” (5:99). He cannot compel assent, and is asked whether he would: “would you then compel the people until they become believers?” (10:99). The register of warning then caps the authority explicitly. He is not a controller over them, *muṣayṭir* (88:22), and not a compeller, “you are not over them a compeller,” *wa-mā anta ‘alayhim bi-jabbār* (50:45). He is not their guardian or keeper either, and the Qur’an denies it twice in different words: “We have not sent you as a keeper over them; upon you is only the conveyance” (42:48), and “We have not made you a keeper over them, nor are you a trustee over them” (6:107). The denial of the keeping is common to both; the conveyance clause belongs to the first alone. And the Qur’an corrects specific exercises of his judgment. It reproves a decision taken over captives of war (8:67) and notes that only a prior decree spared him a severe consequence for it (8:68); it warns him, in a matter of judgment, “do not be an advocate for the treacherous” (4:105). The authority is real and binding, and it is also bounded, delegated, and subject to correction.

Table 2 | Authority and Obedience

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Obedience to him bound to obedience to God; his rulings made binding; a claim on the believers above their own.	His office defined as conveyance; no power to compel assent.	Authority capped: not a controller, not a compeller, not a keeper over them; specific corrections of his judgment.
Context	Establishing his juridical authority and the duty of inward submission.	Marking the limit of his mandate at delivery.	Restraining overreach; correcting a ransom decision and a near-miscarriage of judgment.
Principal verses	al-Nisā' 4:80; al-Nisā' 4:65; al-Aḥzāb 33:6	al-Ghāshiyā 88:21; al-Mā'idā 5:99; Yūnus 10:99	al-Ghāshiyā 88:22; Qāf 50:45; al-Shūrā 42:48; al-Anfāl 8:67-68; al-Nisā' 4:105
Snippet	"Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed God" (4:80); "they will not believe until they make you judge" (4:65)	"you are only a reminder" (88:21); "would you compel the people until they become believers?" (10:99)	"you are not over them a compeller" (50:45); "We have not sent you as a keeper over them; upon you is only the conveyance" (42:48)
Key term (root)	<i>awlā</i> ('-w-l: priority, greater claim); <i>ḥakama</i> (ḥ-k-m: to judge, govern)	<i>balāgh</i> (b-l-gh: to reach, convey); <i>mudhakkir</i> (dh-k-r: to remind)	<i>muṣayṭir</i> (s-ṭ-r: to dominate, oversee); <i>jabbār</i> (j-b-r: to force, compel); <i>ḥafīẓ</i> (ḥ-f-ẓ: to guard, keep)

5. Theme Three: Knowledge and the Unseen

The Prophet's ﷺ access to the unseen is presented under all three registers, and the registers together yield a precise position. In elevation, the Qur'an grants him a disclosure withheld from others: "Knower of the unseen, He discloses His unseen to no one, except a messenger whom He has approved" (72:26-27). It records the supreme vision in which he drew near, "at two bow-lengths' distance or nearer," and in which "the heart did not lie about what it saw" and "the sight did not swerve, nor did it transgress" (53:8-17). It even grants him knowledge of events still to come: against all appearances it foretells that the defeated Romans "after their defeat will be victorious within a few years" (30:2-4), a disclosure of the future set down in the recitation he carried, before the event. In the neutral register he is the reciter of what is sent down, the conveyor of a received word: "it is nothing but a revelation revealed" (53:4).

The register of warning then sets the boundary, and the boundary is sharp. He has no autonomous access to the unseen, no treasures, no angelic nature: "Say: I do not say to you that I possess the treasures of God, nor that I know the unseen, nor do I say to you that I am an angel" (6:50). Had he known the unseen, he says, he would have secured every advantage and suffered no harm (7:188). He does not know his own outcome (46:9), nor the timing of the Hour (7:187). He did not know, before the revelation came, what the Book or the faith was (42:52). His knowledge is incomplete and still arriving, and he is told to pray for its increase: "say: My Lord, increase me in knowledge" (20:114). He is forbidden to hurry the recitation as it descends, to control the very intake of the word (75:16). And the revelation that comes is not his to alter: "Say: It is not for me to change it of my own accord; I only follow what is revealed to me" (10:15). The pattern that unifies the three registers is exact: what knowledge he has of the unseen, and of the future, is granted to him by selection, not possessed or governed by him in his own right.

Table 3 Knowledge and the Unseen			
Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	A singular disclosure granted; the supreme vision; foreknowledge of an event still to come.	His epistemic role as reciter of the revelation he receives.	No autonomous access to the unseen, no foreknowledge of his fate or the Hour; the revelation not his to alter.
Context	The Ascension passage, the descent of revelation, and a prophecy set before its event.	Defining him as the conveyor of a received word.	Answering demands that he display omniscience; disciplining his haste; barring any change to the word.
Principal verses	al-Jinn 72:26-27; al-Najm 53:8-17; al-Rūm 30:2-4	al-Najm 53:4	al-An‘ām 6:50; al-A‘rāf 7:188; al-Aḥqāf 46:9; Yūnus 10:15
Snippet	“He discloses His unseen to no one, except a messenger whom He has approved” (72:26-27); “after their defeat they will be victorious within a few years” (30:3-4)	“it is nothing but a revelation revealed” (53:4)	“I do not know the unseen, nor am I an angel” (6:50); “it is not for me to change it of my own accord” (10:15)
Key term (root)	<i>ghayb</i> (gh-y-b: the hidden, absent); <i>irtaḍā</i> (r-ḍ-w: to approve)	<i>tilāwa</i> (t-l-w: to recite, follow)	<i>ghayb</i> (gh-y-b: the hidden); <i>baddala</i> (b-d-l: to change, exchange)

6. Theme Four: Power, Miracle, and the Limits of Agency

The Qur’an surrounds the Prophet ﷺ with marks of singular divine favor, which belong to the register of elevation because they single his person out for protection and deliverance. God undertakes to shield him: “God will protect you from the people” (5:67). A plot against his life is met and turned (8:30). At the most dangerous hour of the emigration the Qur’an records a tranquility sent down upon him (9:40). His mission itself is framed as a universal mercy. And at the decisive moments his own act is named the act of God. Of the gesture that scattered the enemy at Badr, the text says, “you did not throw when you threw, but God threw” (8:17); of the pledge of allegiance sworn to him under the tree, “those who pledge to you pledge only to God; the hand of God is over their hands” (48:10). These verses stand at the meeting point of the two registers. They are at once the highest exaltation, his hand and his throw made the very vehicle of divine action, and the most complete grounding, for the act is credited not to him but to God. In the neutral register he is the bearer of a recited sign, defined by the functions of warning and good tidings: “We have sent you only as a bringer of good news and a warner” (25:56).

The register of warning then denies him the capacities that earlier prophets displayed and that his adversaries demanded of him. When they ask for gushing springs, a house of gold, an ascent into the sky, the answer reduces him to his created station: “Say: Glory to my Lord. Am I anything but a human messenger?” (17:90-93). His sign is the recited Book, not a wonder produced on demand. He cannot even produce guidance in those he loves: “Indeed, you do not guide whom you love, but God guides whom He wills” (28:56). He holds no power to secure benefit or to repel harm for his own person (7:188). The disposal of the outcome is withheld from him in the plainest words the Qur’an addresses to him, spoken in the aftermath of the reverse at Uḥud: “Not for you is any part of the matter, whether He turns to them in mercy or punishes them, for they are wrongdoers,” *laysa laka min al-amri shay’* (3:128). The verse comes in the middle of a passage about the battle he had just fought and the enemy he had just faced, and it removes from him not the fighting but the disposing. And the revelation itself is not his possession but a trust held at the Giver’s discretion: “And if We willed, We could take away that which We have revealed to you” (17:86). His agency is bounded on every side, and the deliverance, the throw, and the pledge alike are referred to God. The favor reaches its height precisely where the boundary between his action and God’s is declared permeable, and even there the action is God’s.

Table 4 | Power, Miracle, and the Limits of Agency

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Marks of singular favor: protection, deliverance, and his very act made the vehicle of God's act.	His role as warner and herald, bearer of a recited sign.	Denial of miracle on demand, of the power to guide, of self-benefit, and of any part in the disposal of the outcome; the revelation held at God's discretion.
Context	Shielding him amid danger; the throw at Badr and the pledge of allegiance referred to God.	Responding to demands for an angel or a wonder.	Answering the call for spectacular signs; grounding his agency in the aftermath of Uḥud.
Principal verses	al-Mā'ida 5:67; al-Anfāl 8:17; al-Fath 48:10	al-Furqān 25:56	Āl 'Imrān 3:128; al-Isrā' 17:90-93; al-Qaṣaṣ 28:56; al-A'rāf 7:188; al-Isrā' 17:86
Snippet	"you did not throw when you threw, but God threw" (8:17); "the hand of God is over their hands" (48:10)	"We have sent you only as a bringer of good news and a warner" (25:56)	"Not for you is any part of the matter" (3:128); "Am I anything but a human messenger?" (17:93); "you do not guide whom you love" (28:56)
Key term (root)	<i>ramā</i> (r-m-y: to throw); <i>yad</i> (y-d: hand)	<i>nadbīr</i> (n-dh-r: to warn)	<i>amr</i> ('-m-r: command, the matter disposed); <i>bashar</i> (b-sh-r: human being); <i>hadā</i> (h-d-y: to guide)

7. Theme Five: Moral Standing, Reproach, and Repentance

This theme carries the strongest material in both directions, and it is the register in which the Qur'an's accurate portrayal most requires that the corrective verses be reported plainly. In elevation, the Prophet's ﷺ character is commended in the highest terms: "you are of a magnificent character" (68:4), and a comprehensive forgiveness is announced over him (48:2). In the neutral register stands the ethical instruction directed to him as it would be to any believer: he is enjoined to forgiveness, to patience, and to seeking forgiveness, including, strikingly, at the very height of his success, "exalt your Lord with praise and seek His forgiveness, for He is ever-relenting" (110:3). And he is to take no payment for the message he carries, "Say: I ask of you no reward for it" (6:90), so that the revelation is never traded for a price.

The register of warning and accountability records the direct reproaches, the category the tradition named *'itāb al-nabī*. The chapter 'Abasa opens with a reproof delivered in the third person, "He frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him" (80:1-2), at a turning from a blind man who had come for instruction while others of standing were attended to; the grammatical shift into the third person at the moment of the fault is itself a feature of the address. One disclosure is owed here and is made on the same terms as the others in this study. The passage names no referent: it opens in the third person and turns to the second at 80:3,

and the identification of the one reprovved with the Prophet ﷺ is the reading of the commentators and rests on the reported occasion, not on a name in the text. It is adopted here because it is the reading the sūra has carried throughout its reception and because nothing in the analysis turns on it, the passage functioning in this study as an instance of reproof delivered to the one addressed; a reader who declines the identification loses this instance and no step of the argument. In al-Tawba the correction is framed as a pardon that presupposes a lapse: "God has pardoned you; why did you give them permission?" (9:43). The Qur'an attributes *dhanb*, fault, to him explicitly and commands him to seek forgiveness for it (40:55; 48:2).

Two warnings concern the integrity of the message in his keeping, and they are of the severest kind in the whole Qur'an. The first guards against any fabrication against God. The text records that his opponents nearly drew him to invent against God something other than the revelation, and it states the consequence without softening it: had God not made him firm, he might have inclined to them a little, "and then We would have made you taste a double of life and a double of death" (17:73-75). The second is more absolute still. Were he himself to fabricate sayings and attribute them to God, "We would surely have seized him by the right hand, then severed from him the aorta" (69:44-46). And association of others with God, even in his case, would render his own works void: "If you associate others with God, your work will surely come to nothing" (39:65). The most exalted of messengers is held to the most exacting standard, and the threats are stated against him directly.

Table 5 | Moral Standing, Reproach, and Repentance

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	His character commended; a comprehensive forgiveness granted.	Ethical instruction as to any believer; commanded repentance; no payment taken.	Direct reproaches, explicit attribution of fault, and the severest conditional threats, admitting no immunity.
Context	Affirming his moral standing and divine favor.	Enjoining forgiveness and seeking pardon, even at the height of success, asking no wage.	Correcting specific acts; guarding the message against fabrication and against association.
Principal verses	al-Qalam 68:4; al-Faḥ 48:2	al-Naṣr 110:3; al-An‘ām 6:90	‘Abasa 80:1-10; al-Tawba 9:43; al-Isrā’ 17:73-75; al-Ḥāqqa 69:44-46; al-Zumar 39:65
Snippet	“you are of a magnificent character” (68:4)	“exalt your Lord with praise and seek His forgiveness” (110:3); “I ask of you no reward for it” (6:90)	“He frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him” (80:1-2); “We would have seized him by the right hand, then severed from him the aorta” (69:44-46)
Key term (root)	<i>khuluq</i> (kh-l-q: nature, disposition); <i>ghafara</i> (gh-f-r: to cover, forgive)	<i>istaghfir</i> (gh-f-r: to seek covering); <i>ajr</i> (‘-j-r: wage, reward)	<i>dhanb</i> (dh-n-b: tail, that which trails; offense); <i>iftirā’</i> (f-r-y: to fabricate); <i>watīn</i> (w-t-n: aorta)

8. Theme Six: Mortality, Body, and Person

The Qur’an honors the person of the Prophet ﷺ in ways granted to no one else, and these belong to the register of elevation. It swears an oath by his life, “By your life, they were lost in their intoxication” (15:72), conferring on his mortal span the dignity of a thing sworn by. It legislates the sanctity of his presence, forbidding the believers to raise their voices above his (49:2-3). And it consoles him in his distress. When the revelation paused and his opponents taunted that he had been abandoned, the answer came, “your Lord has not forsaken you, nor does He hate you” (93:3); his breast is expanded and his burden lifted, “Did We not expand for you your breast, and remove from you your burden?” (94:1-2).

In the neutral register the Qur’an states his plain humanity. He is a man among his people, and the wonder of his contemporaries that revelation should come to such a one is itself recorded (10:2). He eats and walks the markets, as his adversaries note in mockery (25:7), and the earliest addresses catch him in an ordinary human posture, wrapped in his garments (73:1). The register of warning then affirms

his mortality and exposes his interior. He will die: “Indeed you will die, and indeed they will die” (39:30). No human before him was granted immortality (21:34). His breast is constricted by what his opponents say (15:97), and his grief over their disbelief is named to the edge of self-destruction and then restrained, “perhaps you would destroy yourself with grief over them” (18:6; cf. 26:3). Elsewhere the grief is named and the incapacity named with it in the same breath, and the pairing is exact: “We know that what they say grieves you,” and then, if their turning away is hard upon him, “if you are able to seek out a tunnel into the earth or a ladder into the sky and bring them a sign,” and the sentence is left unfinished, its condition impossible (6:33-35). The consolation offered is not a power granted but the reminder that God could have gathered them all upon guidance had He willed. His humble and dependent origin is recalled without ornament: “Did He not find you an orphan and shelter you, and find you lost and guide you?” (93:6-7). The person who is honored by an oath sworn upon his life is the same person whose beginnings were need on every side, whose inner life bends under hostility, and whose end is death.

Table 6 | Mortality, Body, and Person

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	His person honored: an oath by his life, the sanctity of his presence, and divine consolation in distress.	His plain humanity: a man among his people, subject to hunger and the marketplace.	His mortality, his constricted breast and exposed grief joined to an incapacity named with it, and his humble, dependent origin.
Context	Conferring honor on his person and steadying him when the revelation paused.	Answering mockery that expected a superhuman envoy.	Affirming his death and finitude; restraining his grief; recalling his beginnings.
Principal verses	al-Hijr 15:72; al-Ḍuḥā 93:3; al-Sharḥ 94:1-2	Yūnus 10:2; al-Furqān 25:7; al-Muzzammil 73:1	al-Zumar 39:30; al-Anbiyā' 21:34; al-Hijr 15:97; al-Kahf 18:6; al-An'ām 6:33-35
Snippet	"your Lord has not forsaken you, nor does He hate you" (93:3); "Did We not expand for you your breast?" (94:1)	"What is this messenger that eats food and walks in the markets?" (25:7)	"you will die, and they will die" (39:30); "We know that what they say grieves you" (6:33); "He found you an orphan and sheltered you, found you lost and guided you" (93:6-7)
Key term (root)	<i>'umr</i> ('-m-r: life, lifespan); <i>sharaḥa</i> (sh-r-ḥ: to open, expand)	<i>rajul</i> (r-j-l: a man); <i>ṭa'ām</i> (ṭ-'-m: food)	<i>mawt</i> (m-w-t: death); <i>dāqa</i> (ḍ-y-q: to be constricted)

9. Theme Seven: Rank Among the Prophets, Earthly and Eschatological

The Qur'an affirms that the prophets are not of equal rank: "Those messengers, some of them We favored above others. Among them were those to whom God spoke, and some He raised in degrees" (2:253; cf. 17:55). Against this stands the creed required of the believer, that no distinction be drawn between the messengers in the matter of belief: "we make no distinction between any of His messengers" (2:285). The two do not collide once the distinction is drawn precisely. The favoring is a statement about their stations and is God's to make; the non-distinction is an obligation about faith, that the believer accept all of them without selection, not a claim that their ranks are equal.

Within this frame the Prophet's ﷺ distinctions, stated strictly from the text, are distinctions of finality, of scope, and of covenant. He is the seal who confirms and completes the line (33:40); he is sent comprehensively to all mankind where others were sent to single peoples (34:28); he is named in the solemn covenant taken from the prophets (33:7); and he is promised a praised station, "It may be that your Lord will raise you to a praised station" (17:79). Honest reading requires a further observation. The Qur'an affirms that a ranking exists, but it issues no statement placing him by name above Moses or

Abraham or Jesus. He is told rather that he is no anomaly among them, "Say: I am not a novelty among the messengers" (46:9), and he is enumerated within their chain.

His earthly position even carries certain deficits relative to the earlier prophets, examined in detail in the section that follows: God spoke directly to Moses and supported Jesus with manifest signs and the Holy Spirit (2:253), while the Prophet ﷺ is denied the wonder produced on demand (17:90-93). In the hereafter his distinctions are real and yet bounded. He is granted the praised station and the role of a culminating witness over the communities (4:41; 16:89), but the messengers as a body disclaim knowledge before God on that day (5:109), and intercession is reserved to God and exercised only by His leave: "Say: Intercession belongs wholly to God" (39:44; cf. 2:255). The same limit is set on him in this life and in a number, which is the more striking form of it: he may seek forgiveness for the dissemblers or not seek it, "if you seek forgiveness for them seventy times, God will not forgive them," and the reason given is their own state and not any deficiency in his asking (9:80); the same limit is restated without the number at 63:6, where seeking forgiveness for them and not seeking it are declared alike. His prayer is heard, and it does not compel. His rank is genuine, terminal, and universal in scope, and it remains, in earth and in the hereafter, a rank held under God rather than apart from Him.

Table 7 | Rank Among the Prophets, Earthly and Eschatological

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Distinctions of finality and scope: the Seal, a universal mercy, the praised station, the prophets' covenant.	His standing within the prophetic line, no anomaly among the messengers.	Earthly deficits relative to earlier prophets, a numbered limit on his seeking of forgiveness, and the bounded character of his eschatological role.
Context	Affirming his terminal and universal place in the succession.	Locating him in the chain and in the believer's undifferentiated faith in all messengers.	Comparing his signs to those of Moses and Jesus; capping his intercession in this life by a number and in the next by divine leave.
Principal verses	al-Aḥzāb 33:40; Saba' 34:28; al-Isrā' 17:79; al-Aḥzāb 33:7	al-Aḥqāf 46:9; al-Baqara 2:285	al-Baqara 2:253; al-Isrā' 17:90-93; al-Tawba 9:80; al-Zumar 39:44; al-Baqara 2:255
Snippet	"It may be that your Lord will raise you to a praised station" (17:79)	"I am not a novelty among the messengers" (46:9); "we make no distinction between any of His messengers" (2:285)	"if you seek forgiveness for them seventy times, God will not forgive them" (9:80); "Intercession belongs wholly to God" (39:44)
Key term (root)	<i>khātām</i> (kh-t-m: to seal); <i>maqām</i> (q-w-m: to stand, station)	<i>rusul</i> (r-s-l: messengers); <i>bid'</i> (b-d-': a novelty)	<i>faddala</i> (f-d-l: to favor, give surplus); <i>shafā'a</i> (sh-f-': intercession)

10. Theme Eight: The Prophets Compared, Their Signs and His

The Qur'an never presents the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ in isolation. It sets him within a long succession of messengers and characterizes that succession by the distinctive gift and the distinctive trial of each member. Read comparatively, the prophetic line throws his own endowment into relief, showing what he shares with those before him, what is withheld from him that others were granted, and what is given to him alone.

Each prophet carries a sign suited to his moment. Adam is taught the names of all things, a knowledge before which the angels fall silent (2:31). Noah is given the ark and the long patience of an unanswered call, and is remembered as "a grateful servant" (17:3). Abraham is taken by God as an intimate friend, *khalīl* (4:125), is delivered when the fire is commanded, "O fire, be coolness and peace upon Abraham" (21:69), and is made an *imām* for mankind (2:124). Moses is given the staff before which the sea divides, "and it parted, and each part was like a great mountain" (26:63), the Torah, and a distinction granted to no other in just these words: God "spoke to Moses directly," the verbal noun doubled for emphasis, *kallama Allāhu Mūsā taklīmā* (4:164). Yet even Moses meets a limit, for when he asks to see his Lord the answer is "you will not see Me," *lan tarānī* (7:143). David is given the Psalms and a creation that worships alongside him, "O mountains, echo God's praise with him, and the birds," and iron made soft in his hands (34:10; 21:79). Solomon is taught "the speech of the birds" (27:16), and the wind and the jinn are made subject to him (21:81; 34:12). Joseph is given the reading of dreams and of events (12:6).

The signs gathered around Jesus are the most concentrated of all, and the Qur'an's wording for them is exact. His coming is a creation by the divine word, set in parallel with Adam, "the likeness of Jesus before God is as the likeness of Adam: He created him from dust, then said

to him, Be, and he was" (3:59). He is born of a virgin (19:20). He is himself called a Word from God, *kalima*, "His Word, which He cast to Mary, and a Spirit from Him," *rūḥun minhu* (4:171; 3:45), and he is strengthened with the Holy Spirit (2:87). By God's leave he forms from clay the likeness of a bird and breathes into it and it becomes a bird, and he heals the blind and the leper and raises the dead, each act marked "by God's leave," *bi-idhni Allāh* (3:49; 5:110). And Jesus is given one office that bears directly on the Prophet ﷺ: he announces the one to come, "giving good news of a messenger to come after me whose name is Aḥmad" (61:6), naming him by a name from the same root as Muḥammad, the praised.

Against this array of wonders the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ is given no staff, no parted sea, no clay made to breathe. The Qur'an records of him a night journey (17:1) and speaks of the moon split (54:1), but when his opponents demand a wonder as the price of belief, it redirects them to a sign of an altogether different kind, the recited Book itself: "Is it not enough for them that We have sent down to you the Book that is recited to them?" (29:51), "rather, it is clear signs in the breasts of those given knowledge" (29:49). His miracle is verbal and enduring rather than momentary and local, and the Qur'an stakes it on a challenge no rival speech has met, to bring even a single sūra like it (2:23). He is, in his own mouth, "only a human messenger" (17:93), and his scope is what no prophet before him was given: where "every messenger" was sent "in the tongue of his people" (14:4), he is sent to all mankind and as a mercy to the worlds (34:28; 21:107).

The comparison then turns. The prophets who precede him are made, in the Qur'an, to point toward him. He is found "written with them in the Torah and the Gospel" (7:157); he is the answer to Abraham's own prayer, "Our Lord, raise up among them a messenger from themselves who will recite to them Your verses and teach them the Book and the wisdom" (2:129); and he is the one Jesus names (61:6). The single religion is presented as one across them all, "He has

ordained for you of religion what He enjoined upon Noah, and what We have revealed to you, and what We enjoined upon Abraham and Moses and Jesus” (42:13), and the Qur’an comes “confirming what was before it,” *muṣaddiqan limā bayna yadayhi* (3:3). The thread of divine speech that runs through Moses, who was spoken to, and Jesus, the Word cast to Mary, arrives as the recited Word laid upon the Prophet’s ﷺ heart; the Spirit that is named of Jesus is named also of the revelation given to him, “We have revealed to you a Spirit of Our command” (42:52). He gathers the line and sets his seal upon it.

That sealing is named in a single phrase, *Khātām al-Nabiyyīn* (33:40), and the phrase repays attention to its root. The root *kh-t-m* occurs eight times in the Qur’an, and it is the whole of that census, rather than a selection from it, that fixes the sense; the census also divides cleanly by form, and the division is the substance of the reading. Five occurrences are verbal, and every one of the five is a closure that shuts. God sets a seal upon hearts and hearing so that they no longer receive, “God has set a seal upon their hearts and their hearing” (2:7), and again at 6:46 and 45:23; and a seal is set upon the mouths of the accused so that their own limbs testify in their place, “today We set a seal upon their mouths, and their hands speak to Us” (36:65). The fifth is spoken to the Prophet ﷺ himself as a conditional, “if God willed, He would seal your heart” (42:24), and there the sealing plainly blocks and does not ratify. Nothing in the verbal use, taken alone, would license reading the seal as a certification, and the honest statement of the verb is narrower: it closes decisively and fixes what it marks beyond further alteration.

Three occurrences are nominal, and the certifying sense lives in the noun. Of the wine of the Garden the text says it is “sealed,” *makhtūmin*, and that “its seal is musk,” *khitāmuhu misk* (83:25-26), where the closure is at once a securing and a finish. And *khātām* itself

at 33:40 is the third. The noun is the signet, the ring pressed into clay or wax, and the signet closes a thing precisely by stamping it: the vessel is shut and marked genuine in one act, which the verb of the blocked heart does not do. What the root carries constantly across all eight is therefore decisive closure and fixity; what the nominal form adds, and what 33:40 accordingly carries, is the stamp that authenticates. Read against that usage, *Khātām al-Nabiyyīn* carries more than a position at the end of a sequence. It names the one who confirms and authenticates the whole prophetic line and brings it to completion, the certifying seal set upon all that came before. The familiar rendering “last” captures the aspect of closure, which is the whole of what the verbal uses carry; the noun’s fuller force is consummation, ratification, and the perfecting of what it seals. What such a seal closes, and what it therefore leaves open, is drawn out in Section 24.

The comparison therefore yields the motif once more. The Prophet’s ﷺ distinction among the messengers is not a greater wonder held in his own hand, for the signs that answered a demand and were worked by the messenger’s own act, the staff and the parted sea and the clay made to breathe, are precisely what he is not given. The night journey and the split moon that this section has already recorded are not of that kind: neither is produced by him, neither is offered as the proof his opponents demanded, and the text redirects that demand to the recited Book rather than to either of them. His distinction is a sign of another order, the Word itself, a scope without precedent, and the office of confirming and sealing the line. And even that supreme office is receptive. He seals what was given to others; he is the fulfillment of a prayer and the answer to an announcement; and the seal he sets certifies a prophecy whose author is God. He completes the line. He does not originate it.

Table 8 | The Prophets Compared, Their Signs and His

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	The prophetic line is made to point toward him: foretold in the earlier scriptures, the answer to Abraham’s prayer, named by Jesus; he confirms the line and sets his seal upon it.	The pattern he shares with all messengers: a human envoy carrying the one religion and confirming what came before, no novelty among them.	The spectacular signs granted to earlier prophets are withheld from him; his sign is the recited Book, and he is only a human messenger.
Context	Locating him as the consummation the earlier prophets announced and the seal set upon their succession.	Setting him within the unbroken succession and its single call.	Answering demands that he match the staff of Moses or the signs of Jesus.
Principal verses	al-ʿAʿrāf 7:157; al-Baqara 2:129; al-Ṣaff 61:6; al-Aḥzāb 33:40	al-Aḥqāf 46:9; al-Shūrā 42:13; Āl ʿImrān 3:3	al-ʿAnkabūt 29:49-51; al-Isrāʾ 17:90-93; Āl ʿImrān 3:49
Snippet	“giving good news of a messenger to come after me whose name is Aḥmad” (61:6); “raise up among them a messenger from themselves” (2:129)	“I am not a novelty among the messengers” (46:9); “He has ordained for you of religion what He enjoined upon Noah” (42:13)	“Is it not enough for them that We sent down to you the Book recited to them?” (29:51); “Am I anything but a human messenger?” (17:93)
Key term (root)	<i>khātām</i> (kh-t-m: to seal, certify, complete); <i>Aḥmad</i> (ḥ-m-d: to praise)	<i>muṣaddiq</i> (ṣ-d-q: to confirm, hold true); <i>rusul</i> (r-s-l: messengers)	<i>bayyina</i> (b-y-n: clear proof); <i>idhn</i> (ʿ-dh-n: leave, permission)

11. Theme Nine: Boon and Trial in His Circumstance

The Qur'an does not address the Prophet ﷺ only in the abstract. It meets him in his circumstance, in war and danger, in his household and among his kin, and the meeting carries the same double charge of favor and accountability that runs through the rest of the portrait. The register of elevation here takes the form of boons granted in his lived situation. The most intimate of them answers a wish he never voiced aloud. He had turned his face to the sky in longing, and the response reoriented the worship of the whole community to the direction he desired: "We have seen the turning of your face toward heaven, so We will surely turn you to a qibla you will be pleased with; so turn your face toward the Sacred Mosque" (2:144). After the death of his sons, when his opponents taunted that he was cut off and without posterity, the answer reversed the taunt and granted him abundance instead: "We have granted you al-Kawthar; so pray to your Lord and sacrifice; indeed, it is your hater who is the one cut off" (108:1-3). And his trials were answered with promise: a clear victory was declared his, "We have granted you a clear victory" (48:1), and the true vision of a safe return to Mecca was confirmed before its time, "you will surely enter the Sacred Mosque, God willing, in safety" (48:27).

The neutral register orders his daily and domestic life. His wives are addressed and regulated as a household set apart by his office, "O wives of the Prophet, you are not like any other women" (33:32; cf.

33:28-34), and the etiquette of his home is legislated for the believers who enter it (33:53). He is enjoined to consult those around him and to deal gently with them (3:159), and he asks no payment for his mission beyond the affection due to kinship, "Say: I ask of you no reward for it except love for kinship" (42:23).

The register of warning and accountability is equally present in his circumstance. He is told plainly that he cannot detect the disloyalty within his own ranks, and that God can: "Among the Bedouin around you are hypocrites, and among the people of Madinah who persist in hypocrisy; you do not know them, We know them" (9:101). His own household is the site of a public reproach. In the matter of his marriage he is told that he concealed within himself what God would bring to light, and that he feared the people when God had the greater right to be feared, "you concealed within yourself what God would disclose, and you feared the people, while God has more right that you fear Him" (33:37); and he is reproved for forbidding himself a lawful thing to please his wives, with the further warning that, were he to divorce them, God could give him in their place wives better than they (66:1-5). Even his kinship is bounded by the message: he is forbidden to seek forgiveness for those who died in idolatry, though they be near of kin (9:113), and one of his own uncles is condemned in a sūra of the Qur'an by the name he was known by (111). The favor that bends the qibla to his wish and the correction that exposes his fear of the people are the same address, meeting one man in the full particularity of his life.

Table 9 | Boon and Trial in His Circumstance

Field	Elevation	Neutral / Functional	Warning, Accountability, Criticism
Description	Boons granted in his lived circumstance: worship reoriented to his unspoken wish, abundance after loss, victory promised.	The ordering of his household and the conduct of his mission, asking no payment beyond love of kin.	Betrayal he cannot himself detect, a public reproach within his household, and limits touching his own kin.
Context	Answering his longing and his trials with favor and promise.	Regulating his domestic and communal life.	Warning him of hypocrisy, correcting his conduct toward his wives, and forbidding intercession for idolatrous kin.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:144; al-Kawthar 108:1-3; al-Fath 48:1; al-Fath 48:27	al-Ahzab 33:32; al-Ahzab 33:53; al-Shura 42:23	al-Tawba 9:101; al-Ahzab 33:37; al-Tahrim 66:1-5; al-Tawba 9:113
Snippet	"We have seen the turning of your face toward heaven, so We will turn you to a qibla you will be pleased with" (2:144); "We have granted you al-Kawthar ... it is your hater who is the one cut off" (108:1-3)	"O wives of the Prophet, you are not like any other women" (33:32); "I ask of you no reward for it except love for kinship" (42:23)	"you do not know them, We know them" (9:101); "you concealed within yourself what God would disclose, and you feared the people" (33:37)
Key term (root)	<i>qibla</i> (q-b-l: to face, turn toward); <i>kawthar</i> (k-th-r: abundance)	<i>azwāj</i> (z-w-j: spouse, pair); <i>mawadda</i> (w-d-d: love, affection)	<i>munāfiq</i> (n-f-q: to dissemble); <i>qurbā</i> (q-r-b: nearness, kinship)

12. Theme Ten: The Charge of the Adversary and the Defense

The nine themes to this point have read the portrait as the Qur'an draws it. The text also preserves the portrait as it was contested, the charges his first hearers pressed against the man who recited the Book

and the answers the recitation returned to them. Four themes gather that contest and its root. They are ordered no longer by how the Qur'an addresses him, the three registers of the first movement, but by the three moments of a dispute: the contention raised, the response

the text makes, and the verdict it reaches. The tables of this second movement follow those three.

The first hearers could not agree what he was, and the Qur'an keeps their disagreement as part of its case. He was called a poet, *shā'ir*, root *sh-r*, to perceive and to feel, his recitation reduced to inspired human craft (21:5; 37:36; 52:30). He was called a sorcerer, *sāḥir*, root *s-h-r*, to bewitch, the word read as an enchantment that cleaves households (38:4; 43:30; 74:24). He was called possessed, *majnūn*, root *j-n-n*, to be covered over, his speech explained as a jinni's (15:6; 68:51; 81:22). He was called a soothsayer, *kābin*, whose rhymed cadence his own resembled (52:29; 69:42), a man taught by another standing behind him, *mu'allam* (16:103; 44:14), and a teller of ancient fables, *asātīr al-awwālīn* (25:5; 6:25; 83:13). The labels do not cohere, and the Qur'an makes their incoherence the first answer: "see how they strike comparisons for you, so they stray and cannot find a way" (17:48; 25:9). A man cannot be at once too eloquent and merely raving, bewitched and coldly lying, and the failure of his accusers to settle on one charge is itself the sign that none of them fits.

Beneath the labels lay a heavier charge of a different order. The labels attack his faculty; this one attacks his honesty before God: he fashioned the revelation himself and ascribed it to Heaven. "We never heard this in the latter religion. This is nothing but a fabrication," *in hādihā illā kbtilāq* (38:7), the word formed from *kb-l-q*, the root of creation itself, so that to charge him with *ikhtilāq* is to charge him with the originating act, with fashioning a revelation as though he were its author. Its twin is *iftirā'*, root *f-r-y*, to forge a lie (25:4). And the charge sits, at 38:7, inside the very complaint that asks why the reminder was sent down to one man among them (38:8), the envy that the last register of this movement will name at its root.

The defense the Qur'an sets in his mouth answers not by escalation but by subtraction, and 46:9 is its clearest form. "I am not a novelty among the messengers," *mā kuntu bid'an min al-rusul*, the root *b-d-*

the very root of unprecedented origination, used of God the Originator, *Badī'* (2:117), so that his first word of defense is the denial of being an origination, the exact denial that *ikhtilāq* demands. "Nor do I know what will be done with me or with you," disclaiming the unseen and his own end, the one assurance a forger would never write into his own script. "I only follow what is revealed to me," *in attabi'u illā mā yūḥā ilayya*, root *t-b-*, to follow, the precise opposite of fashioning, repeated at 10:15 where he answers a demand for a different Qur'an that it is not his to alter. "And I am not but a clear warner," *nadhīrun mubīn*, the office stripped to its floor and his speech named clarifying rather than bewitching. Each reduction is a refutation. And the Qur'an does not rest on disavowal but stakes the matter on tests that can be checked: produce a single sūra like it (2:23; 17:88); find the discrepancy a human forgery would leave, "had it been from other than God they would have found in it much *ikhtilāf*" (4:82), the disproof of *ikhtilāq* lying in the absence of *ikhtilāf*, the two words a single letter apart; explain the unlettered man who never read nor wrote before it (29:48) and had lived a lifetime among them reciting nothing (10:16); set the clear Arabic against the foreign tongue of the alleged teacher (16:103); and weigh the self-incrimination, that a forger against God would have been seized by the right hand and his aorta severed (69:44-46), placed one verse before the defense, "if I have invented it, you cannot avail me against God at all" (46:8). The verdict is the photographic negative of the seal already read. The single question dividing the accuser from the accused is whether he originated the word, *ikhtilāq* answering yes and *in attabi'u illā mā yūḥā ilayya* answering no, and the recipient who completes and does not originate is here seen from the dark side. The same axis that clears him condemns the impostor, for the Qur'an's own measure of the false claimant is the mirror of his defense, "who is more unjust than one who invents a lie against God, or says, it has been revealed to me, when nothing was revealed to him" (6:93).

Table 10 | The Charge of the Adversary and the Defense

Field	The Contention	The Text's Response	The Verdict
Description	The labels for what he is, poet, sorcerer, possessed, soothsayer, taught by another, teller of old fables, and the heavier charge that he fabricated the revelation and ascribed it to God.	The incoherence of the labels turned against them, and the defense by subtraction that disclaims origination, foreknowledge, and novelty, staked further on tests that can be checked.	The dividing question is origination alone; the accused disclaims it, and the disclaimer is the negative of the certifying seal.
Context	Reducing the recitation to a human or jinn-borne source, whether craft, madness, enchantment, divination, instruction, or recycled lore, and at the limit to a deliberate forgery.	Answering that no single accusation can be sustained, and that the speaker claims for himself only the following of a received word and the clear warning.	Locating the whole dispute on the axis of authorship, where the portrait of the servant-prophet has already placed him.
Principal verses	al-Anbiyā' 21:5; al-Şaffāt 37:36; Şād 38:4; Şād 38:7; al-Furqān 25:4; al-Naḥl 16:103	al-Aḥqāf 46:8-9; Yūnus 10:15; al-Baqara 2:23; al-Nisā' 4:82; al-'Ankabūt 29:48; al-Ḥāqqa 69:44-46	Şād 38:7-8; al-Aḥqāf 46:9
Snippet	"This is nothing but a fabrication" (38:7); "see how they strike comparisons for you" (17:48)	"I only follow what is revealed to me, and I am not but a clear warner" (46:9)	"had it been from other than God they would have found in it much discrepancy" (4:82)
Key term (root)	<i>ikbtīlāq</i> (kh-l-q: to fashion, fabricate); <i>iftirā'</i> (f-r-y: to forge a lie)	<i>ittibā'</i> (t-b-': to follow); <i>bid'</i> (b-d-': an unprecedented origination)	<i>mubīn</i> (b-y-n: to make clear, distinguish)

13. Theme Eleven: The Sign Demanded and the Sign Given

Where the labels disputed what he was, a further objection prescribed what a messenger must bring, and the Qur'an gathers the demands into a single template of spectacle. He must show God plainly, *arinnā Allāha jabratan*, root *j-b-r*, to be open and manifest (2:55; 4:153). He must bring down a book from the sky to be handled and read (4:153; 17:93; 6:7). He must secure the privilege of Moses, that God speak to the people directly, *lawlā yukallimunā Allāh* (2:118). He must be escorted by a visible angel, or be made an angel himself (6:8; 25:7; 11:12). And Banī Isrā'īl had set the most exacting form of the condition, a messenger who brings an offering that fire from heaven devours, *qurbānin ta'kuluhu al-nār* (3:183). The single thread through every demand is proof by the supernatural made external, visible, and held in the messenger's own hand.

Against every term of that template the Qur'an's messenger is the refusal of it. He is a man who eats and walks the markets, denied the angelic form they require (25:7; "I am only a man like you," 18:110). The whole litany of Meccan demands, that he make a spring gush from the earth, own a garden of palms and vines, drop the sky in

fragments, bring God and the angels face to face, or mount a ladder into heaven, is met not with a wonder but with a disclaimer, "Glory be to my Lord, am I anything but a human messenger" (17:90-93). His sign is not the conjured marvel but the recited Word and the heart it alters, "is it not enough for them that We have sent down to you the Book that is recited to them" (29:51), "rather, it is clear signs in the breasts of those given knowledge" (29:49). The demand wants the sign held outside and shown; the answer gives it heard and carried within.

And the Qur'an does not treat the demand as honest inquiry awaiting its satisfaction. It diagnoses it as evasion. The offering devoured by fire that Banī Isrā'īl required had been brought by messengers before them, "so why did you kill them, if you are truthful" (3:183), and the spectacle the rejecters swore would convince them would not, "even if We sent down to them the angels, and the dead spoke to them, and We gathered everything before them, they would not believe unless God willed" (6:111). The condition is refusal wearing the mask of a test. The verdict is the adversarial face of the first movement's reading of his power: the messenger who holds no marvel in his own hand is the messenger whose only sign is the Word he did not author, the servant once more rather than the sovereign.

Table 11 | The Sign Demanded and the Sign Given

Field	The Contention	The Text's Response	The Verdict
Description	The demand that a true messenger produce spectacle: a plain sight of God, a book sent down to be handled, direct divine speech, a visible angel, an offering consumed by fire.	The portrait of a human messenger who works no marvel on command, whose sign is the recited Word and the transformed heart rather than the external wonder.	The withholding of spectacle is not a deficit but the mark of the servant whose sign is a Word he did not originate.
Context	Setting conditions of supernatural credential, the wonder held in the messenger's own hand, as the price of belief.	Answering with the categorical humanity, the refusal of the wonder-litany, and the internal and enduring sign in place of the local and momentary one.	Reading the demand as evasion, since the condition met before was met with the killing of the prophets who met it.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:55; al-Nisā' 4:153; al-Baqara 2:118; al-Furqān 25:7; Āl 'Imrān 3:183	al-Isrā' 17:90-93; al-Kahf 18:110; al-'Ankabūt 29:49-51	Āl 'Imrān 3:183; al-An'ām 6:111
Snippet	"show us God plainly" (2:55); "why is an angel not sent down to him" (25:7)	"Glory be to my Lord, am I anything but a human messenger?" (17:93)	"so why did you kill them, if you are truthful?" (3:183)
Key term (root)	<i>jahra</i> (j-h-r: to be open, manifest); <i>qurbān</i> (q-r-b: an offering, a drawing near)	<i>bashar</i> (b-sh-r: a human being); <i>bayyina</i> (b-y-n: a clear sign)	<i>āya</i> ('-y-y: a sign)

14. Theme Twelve: The People of the Book and the Awaited One

A different adversary objected on different ground. The People of the Book did not ask what he was, for they knew. They had awaited the prophet their scriptures named, and had sought victory through his coming, "before, they used to seek triumph by him over those who disbelieved," *yastaftihūna 'alā alladhīna kafarū*, root *f-t-h*, to open and to grant the opening of victory (2:89). They recognized him "as they recognize their own sons," *ya'rifūnahu kamā ya'rifūna abnā'ahum* (2:146; 6:20), found "written with them in the Torah and the Gospel" (7:157), the one Jesus had named (61:6). The reported setting of the early biographies, that the Jewish tribes of Yathrib held the coming prophet over the pagan Arabs as a threat of imminent ruin, attaches to this seeking of victory; it is noted here as the historical frame, and the analysis does not rest upon it. The text alone establishes that they had awaited him and knew him when he came.

What the text then records is recognition followed by refusal, and it names the cause. "When there came to them what they recognized, they disbelieved in it" (2:89), and they did so "out of envy that God should send down His grace upon whom He wills of His servants," *baghyan*, root *b-gh-y*, insolent envy (2:90). The grace had fallen outside the lineage, and that was the whole of the offense. Their

criterion became provenance and not truth, "we believe in what was sent down to us and reject what is beyond it," *mā warā'ah*, what lies behind their own enclosure (2:91); a party "cast the Book of God behind their backs" (2:101); and the Qur'an exposes their claim to honor their own prophets as hollow in the same breath, "say, why then did you kill the prophets of God before, if you were believers" (2:91; cf. 2:87).

The answer the Qur'an returns is the undivided line, and it is generous where it might have been only severe. The single religion was ordained alike for Noah and Abraham and Moses and Jesus (42:13); the Book comes "confirming what was before it" (3:3); and the creed it carries "makes no distinction between any of them" (2:136; 3:84), receiving every prophet of theirs without selection. The asymmetry this exposes is the argument itself, that the new community embraces the old prophets whole while the old community rejects the new out of ownership. And to those of the People of the Book who crossed over, the text promises not reproach but a doubled gift, "those will be given their reward twice, for their patience" (28:54), "a double portion of His mercy, and a light by which they walk" (57:28), the door held visibly open. The verdict is that prophecy was never anyone's property, and the line is honored most by those who receive it entire.

Table 12 | The People of the Book and the Awaited One

Field	The Contention	The Text's Response	The Verdict
Description	The People of the Book, who had awaited the foretold prophet and sought victory through him, recognize him and then refuse him out of envy that the grace fell outside their lineage.	The undivided line, the one religion confirming what came before and distinguishing no prophet, with a doubled mercy promised to those of them who believe.	Prophecy is no one's property; the line is honored by reception, not by ownership, and the door stays open.
Context	Measuring him by provenance rather than truth, accepting only what was sent to themselves and rejecting what lay beyond it.	Answering the exclusivist claim with a creed that embraces their own prophets entire, and the rejection with the offer of a reward given twice.	Exposing the asymmetry, that the new community keeps faith with the old prophets the old community itself had killed.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:89; al-Baqara 2:91; al-Baqara 2:146; al-A'raf 7:157; al-Şaff 61:6	al-Baqara 2:136; Āl 'Imrān 3:84; al-Shūrā 42:13; al-Qaşaş 28:54; al-Ĥadid 57:28	al-Baqara 2:90; al-Baqara 2:87
Snippet	"they recognize him as they recognize their own sons" (2:146); "out of envy" (2:90)	"we make no distinction between any of them" (2:136); "a double portion of His mercy" (57:28)	"why then did you kill the prophets of God before?" (2:91)
Key term (root)	<i>baghy</i> (b-gh-y: envy, insolent transgression); <i>istiftāḥ</i> (f-t-ḥ: to seek victory, opening)	<i>kifl</i> (k-f-l: a portion, share); <i>taşdīq</i> (ş-d-q: to confirm, hold true)	<i>farq</i> (f-r-q: to distinguish, divide)

15. Theme Thirteen: Envy and the Sundering of the One Community

The three contests to this point share a single root, and the Qur'an names it and makes it general. Mankind was one community, *ummatan wāḥidatan*, and its division did not come from ignorance. "None differed over it except those who were given it, after the clear proofs had come to them, out of envy among themselves," *baghyān baynabum* (2:213). That formula returns almost word for word three times more, for four occurrences in all: "they did not differ except after knowledge had come to them, out of envy among themselves" (3:19; 42:14; 45:17). The one affair was severed by their own hands, "they cut their affair into pieces among themselves," *taqaṭṭa'ū amrabum baynabum* (21:92-93; 23:52-53), until "each faction rejoices in what it holds" (30:32), and they "divided their religion and became sects," *shiya'an* (6:159). The cause the Qur'an assigns to the divisions it names is not the absence of knowledge but the presence of envy after it. Where a schism answers that description, and the text says of these that it does, it is *baghy* wearing the robe of doctrine.

Read together with the contests that precede it, the envy here is seen to wear three coats over one body. It is the angel's pride of substance, Iblis refusing the prostration to Adam with "I am better than him," *ana khayrun minhu* (7:12). It is the clansman's pride of place, the

Meccans asking "has the reminder been sent down on him alone among us" (38:8). It is the heir's pride of lineage, Banī Isrā'īl resenting that grace was given outside the bloodline (2:90). One envy and three theaters, and the same envy at last fractures the one religion into rival sects among the very family of the prophets, to each of whom was sent "their brother" under a single ordained way, the messenger being the brother of the people he is sent to and not one sent to a brother (7:65; 7:73; 42:13).

The Qur'an does not leave this as an indictment of others, and the register that turns the lesson is the one to hold above the rest. The verse that draws the moral is addressed to the believers themselves, "do not be like those who divided and differed after the clear proofs came to them" (3:105), and "each faction rejoicing in what it has" (30:32) is aimed at everyone who fractures, the believing community first among them. The People of the Book are the cautionary case and not a uniquely fallen people; the envy diagnosed is the universal disease of the human breast that the whole portrait of the servant-prophet has been set against. The verdict, then, is not a triumph over a neighbor but a diagnosis turned inward, and it sets the question the final movement of this study takes up: if envy is what sundered the one community, what in the portrait of the seal heals it, and what, with the contest answered and its root laid bare, the text holds open to the one who reads.

Table 13 | Envy and the Sundering of the One Community

Field	The Contention	The Text's Response	The Verdict
Description	The one community sundered into rival sects, each faction holding its portion and rejecting the rest, the single religion divided among the family of the prophets.	The cause named, four times over, as envy after knowledge rather than ignorance, the same envy that refused at the angelic, the tribal, and the scriptural turn.	A diagnosis turned inward, the warning addressed first to the believers, not a verdict pronounced over others.
Context	The fracturing of an originally single community, knowledge present and assent withheld, doctrine made the robe of rivalry.	Tracing the rupture to <i>baghy</i> , and gathering its three forms, the pride of substance, of place, and of lineage, under one root.	Setting the question the seal's open path will answer, how the sundering is healed.
Principal verses	al-Baqara 2:213; al-Anbiya' 21:92-93; al-Mu'minun 23:52-53; al-Rum 30:32	Al 'Imran 3:19; al-Shura 42:14; al-Jathiya 45:17; al-Araf 7:12	Al 'Imran 3:105; al-An'am 6:159
Snippet	"they cut their affair into pieces among themselves" (23:53); "each faction rejoicing in what it has" (30:32)	"they did not differ except after knowledge had come to them, out of envy" (45:17)	"do not be like those who divided and differed" (3:105)
Key term (root)	<i>shiya'</i> (sh-y-': factions, sects); <i>taqaṭṭu'</i> (q-ṭ-': to cut into pieces)	<i>baghy</i> (b-gh-y: envy, insolent transgression)	<i>furqa</i> (f-r-q: division, separation)

16. Theme Fourteen: The Slander and the Vindication

The thirteen themes to this point have read the portrait and the contest brought against it. The text also met the Prophet ﷺ in the particular crises of his life, and the third movement of this study reads those meetings. They are not aspects of how he is drawn, nor charges to be answered, but trials, and what they share is one pattern that confirms all that has gone before: in each, the resolution descends from God and is not produced by the Prophet ﷺ himself. The tables of this movement mark the trial faced, the divine response sent down, and the resolution it works.

The gravest assault on his peace came not against his doctrine but against his household. A rumor spread that a woman of his household had been unfaithful, and it ran through the community while he had no answer to it; that the woman was 'Ā'isha is the reported setting, which the text does not name and the reading here does not require. The Qur'an records the ordeal without softening his helplessness in it, naming the affliction *al-ifk*, the lie, "those who brought the slander are a band among you" (24:11), and it does not show him ending the matter by his own authority or his own conviction. He waited, as the community waited, for the word from above.

The clearing came by revelation and not by his defense. The Qur'an issued the absolution in a general formula that names no one, "they are absolved of what they say; for them is forgiveness and a noble provision" (24:26), the application to his household being the reported setting and not a naming in the text, and turned the affair into law for all: a charge of this kind requires four witnesses, and absent them the accusers are themselves at fault (24:13); to repeat what one has not verified is no small thing, "you took it up with your tongues and spoke with your mouths what you had no knowledge of, and reckoned it a trifle, while with God it was great" (24:15). The honor of the household was restored from above, and the one who spoke the slander, not the one it was spoken against, was condemned.

The pattern is the one the whole study has traced, met here at its most personal. In the crisis nearest his heart the Prophet ﷺ is not the agent of his own vindication; he is its recipient. The reversal is the same the text had worked when his enemies called him cut off, *abtar*, and the answer came that the abundance was his and the hater was the one cut off (108:1-3). What lay behind the taunt, the deaths of his sons, is the reported occasion and is noted as such; the text carries the taunt and the answer and not the bereavement. His honor, like his message, is given to him and not generated by him, and the slander against his house is answered by the same hand that answers every other trial.

Table 14 | The Slander and the Vindication

Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	A month-long slander against the Prophet's ﷺ wife, which he could not end by his own word and for which he awaited revelation.	A direct vindication sent down from God, with the affair made into law: four witnesses required, and the careless tongue rebuked.	His honor is restored from above; he is the recipient of his vindication, not its agent.
Context	The assault falls on his household rather than his doctrine, and finds him without an answer of his own.	Absolving the accused, condemning the accuser, and legislating the standard of proof and the gravity of rumor.	The kindred reversal of the taunt of being cut off, answered by al-Kawthar, is of one piece with this.
Principal verses	al-Nūr 24:11-12	al-Nūr 24:13; al-Nūr 24:15; al-Nūr 24:26	al-Kawthar 108:1-3
Snippet	“those who brought the slander are a band among you” (24:11)	“they are absolved of what they say; for them is forgiveness and a noble provision” (24:26)	“it is your hater who is the one cut off” (108:3)
Key term (root)	<i>ifk</i> (ʿ-f-k: to lie, slander, overturn)	<i>baraʿa</i> (b-r-ʿ: to absolve, declare innocent)	<i>kawthar</i> (k-th-r: abundance)

17. Theme Fifteen: The Law He Did Not Make

A woman came to him with a grievance for which he had no ruling. Her husband had cast her off by the old formula of *ṣihār*, declaring her as forbidden to him as his mother's back, a pronouncement that left her neither divorced nor wed, and she pleaded her case and complained to God. The Qur'an opens the sūra named for her, *al-Mujādila*, She Who Disputes, by marking that her plea was heard in heaven before it was answered on earth, “God has heard the speech of the woman who disputes with you concerning her husband and complains to God, and God hears your dialogue” (58:1). The Prophet ﷺ himself had given her no answer, for there was none to give until it was sent down.

The law came from above and not from him. God annulled the old formula, named it “an objectionable saying and a falsehood,” and set in its place a graduated expiation (58:2-4). And the same hand governs the most scrutinized event of his own household, the marriage to

Zaynab, the former wife of his adopted son. The Qur'an had already severed adoption from sonship, “He has not made your adopted sons your sons; call them by their fathers” (33:4-5), and it records that he married her by command, to fix in law that an adopted son is not a son, while reproving him in the same verse for having feared the people when God had the greater right to be feared (33:37). Neither the woman's relief nor his own marriage is his ruling. Both are legislated for him.

Here the servant-prophet stands at the precise point where a founder would be expected to legislate, and he does not. He cannot resolve the woman's plight by his own judgment, and he cannot order his own household by his own preference; the answer to her and the breaking of the taboo for him descend as revelation, and he is corrected even in the manner of receiving it. The one who only follows what is revealed (46:9) is shown following it into the law itself, which is given to him and never authored by him.

Table 15 | The Law He Did Not Make

Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	A woman's plea against an unjust formula of divorce, for which the Prophet ﷺ has no ruling, and the charged question of his own marriage.	The law sent down, annulling the formula and setting an expiation, and the command that settles his household and abolishes adoption.	He legislates nothing of his own; the law and even his marriage are given to him, and he is reproved in receiving them.
Context	The case finds him without an answer until revelation comes; the marriage breaks a taboo only by command.	God hears the plea before it is answered, and decides both the woman's relief and the Prophet's ﷺ own affair.	The servant who only follows what is revealed is shown following it into the law itself.
Principal verses	al-Mujādila 58:1; al-Aḥzāb 33:37	al-Mujādila 58:2-4; al-Aḥzāb 33:4-5	al-Aḥqāf 46:9
Snippet	“God has heard the speech of the woman who disputes with you” (58:1)	“He has not made your adopted sons your sons; call them by their fathers” (33:5)	“you feared the people, while God has more right that you fear Him” (33:37)
Key term (root)	<i>jidāl</i> (j-d-l: to dispute, argue)	<i>ṣihār</i> (ṣ-h-r: the back, the old formula of repudiation)	<i>daʿīyy</i> (d-ʿ-w: an adopted son, one called to another)

18. Theme Sixteen: The Knowledge Bounded Under Question

He was tested with questions meant to expose the limit of what he knew. The reported setting of the early literature, that his opponents sought from the learned of the People of the Book three questions to put to him, the companions of the cave, the traveler of the two horizons, and the spirit, is the biographical frame, and the analysis does not rest upon it. What the text establishes is that on the hardest of the three the answer given was a confession of limit: “they ask you about the spirit; say, the spirit is of the command of my Lord, and you have not been given of knowledge except a little” (17:85).

The Qur’an answers the other two questions at length, in the narratives of the sleepers of the cave and of Dhū al-Qarnayn (18:9-26; 83-98), and in the telling it corrects the Prophet ﷺ himself for a presumption of his own. He had promised an answer on the morrow

without referring it to the will of God, and the rebuke is set into the sūra, “do not say of anything, I will surely do that tomorrow, except that God wills,” and remember your Lord if you forget (18:23-24). And where the People of the Book brought him a case for judgment, he was to rule not by his own mind but by the Book they already held, “how is it they come to you for judgment while they have the Torah, in which is the judgment of God” (5:43), for “We revealed the Torah, in it guidance and light” (5:44).

The trial of his knowledge returns the finding of the third theme of the first movement, now under examination. His knowledge is a granted and bounded thing, not a possessed and unlimited one; his very promises are corrected when they presume upon the unseen; and his judgments are referred to revelation, his own and that given before him. The interrogation meant to find the limit of the man finds exactly the limit the Qur’an everywhere draws, knowledge given in measure and the rest with God alone.

Table 16 The Knowledge Bounded Under Question			
Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	Questions designed to probe the limit of his knowledge, the hardest answered by a confession that he was given of knowledge only a little.	The two narratives given as answer, the correction of his presumption to promise without God’s will, and the command to judge by the revealed Book.	His knowledge is bounded, his promises corrected, his judgment derived; the limit found is the one the text everywhere draws.
Context	An interrogation framed to expose him, on the spirit and on two narratives of the past.	Answering the narratives, rebuking the presumption upon the unseen, and referring judgment to the Torah’s own ruling.	The bounded knowledge of the first movement, now shown under the test.
Principal verses	al-Isrā’ 17:85	al-Kahf 18:23-24; al-Mā’ida 5:43-44	al-Kahf 18:9-26; 18:83-98
Snippet	“you have not been given of knowledge except a little” (17:85)	“do not say of anything, I will surely do that tomorrow, except that God wills” (18:23-24)	“We revealed the Torah, in it guidance and light” (5:44)
Key term (root)	<i>rūḥ</i> (r-w-ḥ: spirit, breath)	<i>mashī’a</i> (sh-y-’: will, what God wills)	<i>ḥukm</i> (ḥ-k-m: judgment, ruling)

19. Theme Seventeen: The Frown and the Firmness

Twice the Qur’an met him at the edge of his own conduct in the mission, once in a fault of manner and once in a danger of substance. The first is the reproach of *‘Abasa*. A blind man came seeking knowledge while the one addressed was occupied with the powerful he hoped to win, and he frowned and turned away; the identification of that one with the Prophet ﷺ rests on the reported occasion and not on a name in the text, as Section 7 records, and is adopted here on the terms stated there. The rebuke is direct and opens the sūra in the third person, as if to hold the act at arm’s length, “He frowned and turned away that the blind man came to him; and what would make you know, perhaps he would be purified” (80:1-4). The one who sought was worthier of his attention than the one whose favor he courted, and the text says so to his face.

The second is graver, a pull not of manner but of message. The Qur’an records that he was nearly drawn to soften what was revealed in order to win his opponents, and that God held him, “they almost tempted you away from what We revealed to you, that you might invent against Us something else, and then they would have taken you as a friend; and had We not made you firm, you would have nearly inclined to them a little” (17:73-74). The firmness was God’s gift and not his own resolve. This is the place where the contested story of the cranes is sometimes set, and it is set in its place here, anchored not to that narrative, which the text does not carry, but to the firmness verses and to the general law of 22:52, read as in Section 24 with the lexical dispute over *tamannā* recorded there: that no prophet was so approached but that Satan cast something in, which God then annuls and makes firm.

Both episodes return the servant under correction and under protection, and from the same source. He is reproved for the frown and held firm against the temptation, and neither the reproof nor the

holding originates in him. The reproaches the tradition gathered under the name *ʿitāb al-nabī* and the protection that kept the message unaltered are two acts of one care, the care of God for a servant who

could err in manner and could be tempted in substance, and was carried through both.

Table 17 The Frown and the Firmness			
Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	A fault of manner, the frown at the blind seeker, and a danger of substance, the pull to soften the message to win the powerful.	A direct reproach for the frown, and a firmness granted from God that held him from inclining, with the casting purified.	Correction and protection both descend from God; the firmness is His gift, not the Prophet's ﷺ own resolve.
Context	The mission's own edges, where his attention strays to the strong and his resolve is nearly bent.	Rebuking the slight to the seeker and holding him firm against the temptation to invent something other than what was revealed.	The contested story of the cranes set in its place, anchored to the firmness verses and not asserted as event.
Principal verses	'Abasa 80:1-4; al-Isrā' 17:73	al-Isrā' 17:74; al-Ḥajj 22:52	al-Aḥqāf 46:9
Snippet	"He frowned and turned away that the blind man came to him" (80:1-2)	"had We not made you firm, you would have nearly inclined to them a little" (17:74)	"God abolishes what Satan casts, then God makes His verses firm" (22:52)
Key term (root)	<i>'abasa</i> ('-b-s: to frown, scowl)	<i>tatbbit</i> (th-b-t: to make firm, steady)	<i>fitna</i> (f-t-n: trial, temptation)

20. Theme Eighteen: The Unseen Audience and the Staked Truth

Two trials stretched his mission past its visible bounds, one downward into the unseen and one outward into open confrontation. In the first, a company he could not see came to hear him. The Qur'an records that a band of the jinn listened to the recitation and believed, "say, it has been revealed to me that a company of the jinn listened, and they said, we have heard a wondrous recitation that guides to right conduct, so we believed in it" (72:1-2; cf. 46:29-32). His audience was wider than the human, and the Word reached where his own sight did not.

In the second, the Christians of Najran disputed with him over the nature of Jesus, and the Qur'an gave him not an argument to win but a trial to propose, the *mubāhala*, the mutual imprecation, "whoever

disputes with you about him after the knowledge that has come to you, say, come, let us call our sons and your sons, our women and your women, ourselves and yourselves, then let us invoke and place the curse of God upon the liars" (3:61). The truth is not staked on his eloquence or his standing but on God's own judgment between the parties, the liar to be exposed by Heaven and not by the man.

Both trials carry the same mark. The reach to the jinn is the reach of the recited Word and not of his person; they believe on hearing it, as men do, and the wonder is the recitation and not the reciter. And the confrontation with Najran is handed, at its sharpest, to God to decide, the imprecation calling down a verdict the Prophet ﷺ does not himself pronounce. Where his mission passed beyond the seen and where it met its hardest denial, the resolution belonged to God, and the servant only carried the Word and proposed the trial.

Table 18 | The Unseen Audience and the Staked Truth

Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	An unseen company of jinn who came to hear the recitation, and an open dispute with the Christians of Najran over the nature of Jesus.	The Word reaching the jinn, who believe on hearing it, and the proposal of a mutual imprecation that hands the verdict to God.	The reach is the Word's, not his person's; the confrontation is decided by God, not by his own claim.
Context	His mission stretched beyond the visible audience and met its hardest denial in open argument.	The jinn guided by the recitation, and the dispute settled by calling God's curse upon whichever party lies.	The servant carries the Word and proposes the trial; the resolution is God's.
Principal verses	al-Jinn 72:1-2; al-Aḥqāf 46:29-30	Āl 'Imrān 3:61	al-Jinn 72:13
Snippet	"a company of the jinn listened, and they said, we have heard a wondrous recitation" (72:1-2)	"let us invoke and place the curse of God upon the liars" (3:61)	"when we heard the guidance, we believed in it" (72:13)
Key term (root)	<i>jinn</i> (j-n-n: the hidden, the unseen)	<i>ibtihāl</i> (b-h-l: to invoke earnestly, to imprecate)	<i>rushd</i> (r-sh-d: right guidance, sound conduct)

21. Theme Nineteen: The Enemy Within and the Conduct of the Struggle

The hardest enemies of his community were not the open ones but the hidden, and against these the Prophet ﷺ was given no power of detection. The Qur'an states it plainly: among those around him were hypocrites he could not know and God could, "among the Bedouin around you are hypocrites, and among the people of Madinah, persistent in hypocrisy; you do not know them, We know them" (9:101; cf. 63:1-8). The reported account that he confided the names of certain of them to a single companion is biography; what the text establishes is the limit, that the inner enemy is hidden from him and exposed only from above.

Against the open enemy, the Qur'an did not leave him to his own measure but bound his conduct to a law of restraint. He is to fight only those who fight him and never to transgress, "fight in the way of God those who fight you, and do not transgress; God loves not the

transgressors" (2:190); to incline to peace when the enemy inclines to it, "and if they incline to peace, incline to it, and rely upon God" (8:61); to grant asylum to the very enemy who seeks to hear God's word and then convey him to safety (9:6); and to deal justly and kindly with those who did not fight him (60:8). The contest of words is fenced too, the believing poet permitted to answer only after wrong, among "those who believe and do righteous deeds and remember God much and defend themselves after they were wronged" (26:227).

The crisis of the enemy, within and without, returns the same servant. He cannot see the hypocrite, and the exposure is God's; he does not set the rules of the struggle, and the restraint is commanded; even the answering of slander in verse is bounded by the law of the wronged. The one who holds no autonomous power over outcomes, as the first movement had already established, is shown holding none here, in the gravest matters of war and loyalty, where a sovereign would rule by his own will and the servant rules by the law sent down to him.

Table 19 | The Enemy Within and the Conduct of the Struggle

Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	The hidden enemy he cannot detect, the hypocrites within, and the open enemy in war and in the contest of words.	God's exposure of the hypocrites whom He alone knows, and a law of restraint, asylum, and justice binding the conduct of the struggle.	He neither sees the inner enemy nor sets the rules of war; the exposure and the restraint both come from God.
Context	The community subverted from within and pressed from without, in arms and in the war of words.	Naming the hidden as known to God, and fencing the open struggle with limit, mercy, and the law of the wronged.	The servant who holds no power over outcomes is shown holding none in war and loyalty.
Principal verses	al-Tawba 9:101; al-Munāfiqūn 63:1	al-Baqara 2:190; al-Anfāl 8:61; al-Tawba 9:6; al-Mumtaḥana 60:8	al-Shu'ara' 26:227
Snippet	"you do not know them, We know them" (9:101)	"if they incline to peace, incline to it, and rely upon God" (8:61)	"and defend themselves only after they were wronged" (26:227)
Key term (root)	<i>nifāq</i> (n-f-q: hypocrisy, dissembling)	<i>salām</i> (s-l-m: peace, submission)	<i>intīṣār</i> (n-ṣ-r: to defend, vindicate oneself)

22. Theme Twenty: The Vulnerable Prophet and the Refuge

The movement closes its trials where he is most exposed, in his own body and person. He is, the text insists throughout, a man like other men, and the reported account that he was once afflicted by sorcery, knots tied against him, belongs to the biographical literature and is contested within it; it is noted as the occasion the tradition assigns and is not asserted here as event. What the text itself establishes is the premise beneath it, that he was vulnerable as men are vulnerable, holding no charm against harm in himself, subject to the evil eye and the whisper and the malice of others as any servant is.

The Qur'an's answer to that vulnerability is not to make him invulnerable but to give him a refuge to recite. The two closing sūras, the *mu'awwidhatān*, are exactly this provision, placed in his mouth and every believer's: refuge in the Lord of daybreak "from the evil of what He created, and from the evil of darkness when it gathers, and from the evil of the blowers upon knots, and from the evil of an envier

when he envies" (113:1-5), and refuge in the Lord of mankind "from the evil of the slinking whisperer, who whispers in the breasts of mankind, of jinn and of men" (114:1-6). The protection is sought, not possessed; it is a word he is given to say, not a power he holds.

This is the servant-prophet at his plainest. He is not armored against the harms that reach other men; he is taught to take refuge in God against them, and the refuge is the recited word once more. The envier's malice that the People of the Book had shown him, the whisper that troubled every breast and that the prophets too were made firm against, and the ordinary evils of the dark, are met not by an invulnerability in his person but by a turning to God that any servant may make. The last provision of the trials is the same as the first: the protection, like the vindication and the law and the firmness, comes from God, and the man holds nothing of it in himself. The refuge is a word given to every believer no less than to him, and what that openness means for the one who comes after is drawn out in Section 24.

Table 20 | The Vulnerable Prophet and the Refuge

Field	The Trial	The Divine Response	The Resolution
Description	His own vulnerability to harm, the evil eye, the whisper, the malice of others, with the contested account of sorcery as its reported occasion.	Not invulnerability but a refuge to recite, the two closing sūras placing protection in his mouth and every believer's.	He is not armored against harm; he is taught to seek refuge in God, and the protection is a word, not a power.
Context	The man like other men, exposed in body and person to the harms that reach all men.	Refuge in the Lord of daybreak and the Lord of mankind, from the created evils, the envier, and the slinking whisperer.	The first and last note of the trials is one: the protection, like all else, comes from God.
Principal verses	al-Falaq 113:4-5; al-Nās 114:4-5	al-Falaq 113:1-5; al-Nās 114:1-6	al-Kahf 18:110
Snippet	“from the evil of an envier when he envies” (113:5)	“I seek refuge in the Lord of daybreak, from the evil of what He created” (113:1-2)	“Say, I am only a man like you, to whom it is revealed” (18:110)
Key term (root)	<i>ḥasad</i> (ḥ-s-d: envy, the envious eye)	<i>ʿawdh</i> (ʿ-w-dh: to seek refuge, take shelter)	<i>waswās</i> (w-s-w-s: the whisper, insinuation)

23. Synthesis: The Coherence of the Portrait

The themes return the same finding from three sides. The nine of the portrait return it directly. The four of the contest return it in the negative, the charge that he originated the word answered by his own disclaimer, the demand for spectacle answered by the servant who holds no marvel in his hand, the rejection of the awaited one explained by the envy that sunders every community. And the seven of the trial return it under fire, the slander answered by revelation and not by his defense, the law given and not authored, the knowledge bounded and the firmness granted, the unseen reached by the Word and the confrontation handed to God, the hidden enemy exposed from above and the very refuge from harm a word he is told to say. The Qur'an raises the Prophet ﷺ to the limit of created standing and, at every turn, withholds from him the one thing that would make him an independent source rather than a maximal recipient. The motif is not a contest between exaltation and grounding that the text fails to resolve. It is a single theology of the servant-prophet, and two observations make its coherence plain.

The first observation concerns the grammar of his elevation, which is receptive throughout. His names are receptive: Muḥammad is the one praised, by another, from the root *ḥ-m-d* that also names the praising God. His office is receptive: *rasūl*, the one sent, by a sender. His highest title is receptive in the strongest sense: *ʿabd*, servant, the word the Qur'an chooses at the summit of his ascent. Even the marks of favor are framed as the action of the Giver, not the possession of the favored: God protects him, God suffices him, God expands his breast and lifts his burden, all in the divine first person. The receptivity reaches its limit in the small class of verses where his own act is named the act of God, and the class has two members, with a third passage standing beside it at a lower strength. At Badr, of the gesture that scattered the enemy, the text says “you did not throw when you threw, but God threw” (8:17). Of the pledge sworn to him, “the hand of God is over their hands” (48:10). Both carry the feature that defines the class, the identification of the human act with the divine act: the

first by negating the throw and reassigning it, the second by laying the divine hand over the hands that pledge. A third passage is adjacent, and is recorded here as adjacent rather than as a member. In a passage on those who confessed their faults he is told “take from their wealth an offering,” *ḥudh*, and one verse later the same verb is used of God, “do they not know that it is God who accepts the turning of His servants and takes the offerings,” *yaḥbudhu al-ṣadaqāt* (9:103-104). Nothing there is negated and nothing is transferred by a figure, and that absence is exactly what holds it below the two: one verb is predicated of two agents at two registers, the servant taking the coin and God receiving the offering, and the text nowhere says that his taking is God's taking. It is a resonance rather than an identification, and it is worth recording as the softer form of the same pattern. The two members of the class are at once the highest exaltation, his hand and his throw made the very vehicle of divine action, and the most complete grounding, for the act is credited not to him but to God. The same permeability runs in the other direction in the matter of the qibla: God saw his face turning to the sky in silent longing and turned the worship of the community to the direction he desired (2:144). Between the throw that is God's and the qibla that bends to his wish, the Prophet ﷺ stands as the place where the human will and the divine meet, the locus through which God acts and to whose longing God answers, never an independent power set beside Him.

The comparison with the earlier prophets confirms the same reading from another side. His distinction among them is not that a greater wonder was placed in his hand, for the staff, the healing breath, and the clay made to breathe are precisely the signs he is not given; his sign is the recited Word, and his scope and his office of confirming and sealing the line are what set him apart. Even this supremacy is receptive. He is the answer to Abraham's prayer and the one Jesus names, foretold by the line he completes; he confirms what was given to others rather than originating it; and the seal he sets, in the full sense the noun carries, certifies and consummates a prophecy whose author is God. To seal the prophets, on the Qur'an's own usage of the

noun *khātām* and not of the verb that shuts a heart, is to ratify and complete them, not to stand merely as their terminus.

The second observation concerns the corrective verses, and it is here that the portrait's deepest coherence lies. The reproaches and the commands to repent are not a weight that drags against his rank. They are the substance of it, and the Qur'an supplies its own paradigm for reading them. The text sets the election of Adam after his fault and not before it, and says so in a single sentence: "and Adam disobeyed his Lord and went astray; then his Lord chose him, and turned to him, and guided" (20:121-122). The order is the whole of the point. He deviates, receives words of return from his Lord, and is turned to (2:36-37); and only then is he chosen. Against him stands the refuser, who deviates and justifies himself, claiming an inherent superiority, "I am better than him" (7:12), and does not return. Two parties err and one is raised, and what parts them is the returning. One boundary must be kept, because the study's own method requires it: the prostration commanded of the angels stands at 2:34, before the fall, and the ground the passage gives for it is the teaching of the names and the angels' confession that they know only what they were taught (2:31-33). That honoring is not grounded in corrigibility, and it is not offered here as though it were. What the text grounds in the returning is the election at 20:122, and that is enough, because it is the election and not the prostration that this study's paradigm needs. On this paradigm the Prophet's ﷺ corrigibility is not the floor beneath his station. It is the station's own mechanism. He is the one in whom this human capacity operates at its fullest, and the Qur'an marks the point unmistakably by issuing the command to seek forgiveness not in a moment of failure but at the summit of his victory, when the conquest is complete: "exalt your Lord with praise and seek His forgiveness" (110:3). The crown of his success is an act of turning.

Read together, the observations explain why the apparent tensions in the portrait are not tensions at all. The same root that grounds him as flesh, *b-sh-r*, furnishes the word for his commission as herald, *bashīr*: the human being who can err is the very one who is sent. The character commended as magnificent (68:4) is corrected in its particular acts (80:1; 33:37; 66:1), because the perfected human is governed and not self-governing. The favor that bends the qibla to his wish and the abundance that answers his loss single him out, yet originate wholly in the Giver; the betrayals he cannot detect and the reproaches within his household ground him as a man among men, under God's correction as under God's protection. The bearer of two of the divine names, *ra'ūf* and *rahīm*, is the same servant who is told he holds no power to benefit himself, because the names are bestowed and not owned. And the comparison with the earlier prophets resolves on the same principle: the favoring of one prophet above another is God's to assign, and the Prophet's ﷺ terminal and universal place is a place within the divine economy, not a rank he occupies apart from it.

This reading does not soften the reproaches to protect the Prophet's ﷺ dignity, and it has no need to. It locates the dignity in the very capacity the reproaches presuppose. A prophet who could not be addressed in correction would be, on the Qur'an's own Adamic logic,

lower and not higher, nearer to the condition the refusing party claimed for itself than to the condition for which Adam was raised. The most exalted of messengers is held to the most exacting standard, warned that fabrication against God would cost him the aorta and that association would void his works, precisely because the standard rises with the station. The honor and the accountability are not opposed values held in uneasy balance. In the Qur'anic portrait they are forged from a single material, and the text says as much in its own grammar, when it makes the servant the one it praises, the throw of his hand the throwing of God, and the seeking of forgiveness the crown of his victory.

24. The Seal and the Open Path

The portrait, its contesting, the trials that proved it, and their synthesis settle the matter: a servant-prophet whose greatness is the greatness of reception, raised to the limit of created standing and withheld at every turn from being an independent source, accused of originating the word he only carried and cleared by the same text, and met in every crisis by a resolution he received and did not make. One question the themes imply but do not separately resolve remains, and it is the question the title of this study has carried throughout. What does the seal close, and what does it leave open. The word has already been read here at its root and in its form, the signet that closes and authenticates and completes, and read by the Qur'an's own nominal usage rather than as a bare terminus. Read so, it falls in the text upon a defined thing. The single sealing term the Qur'an sets upon the Prophet ﷺ falls upon the prophets, *khātām al-nabiyyīn* (33:40). What the seal closes is the office of prophecy, the descent of a new revelation upon a newly commissioned man. What the text is nowhere reticent about, and nowhere closes, is guidance.

One observation about the wording of 33:40 should be recorded and then held to its size, because it has been made to carry far more than it can bear. The Qur'an sets no parallel sealing term upon the messengers; there is no *khātām al-mursalīn* in the text. Two readings of that silence are available and this study does not need to choose between them, which is the point worth making. On the first and standard reading, *nubuwwa* is the broader office and *risāla* the narrower, every messenger being a prophet and not every prophet a messenger, in which case sealing the broader class seals the narrower within it and the absence of a second term is redundancy rather than reticence. The Qur'an's own usage lends this reading direct support in a verse this study has already cited in Section 19 and cites again below for another purpose, where the two offices are coordinated in a single construction, "We sent no messenger before you and no prophet but that when he *tamannā*, Satan cast something into his *umniyya*" (22:52), the verb read here in the reciting sense for the reasons given below; the pairing there treats them as one class under one law, not as two compartments. On the second reading the silence is simply silence, and where the text does not pronounce it does not pronounce. Nothing in this section turns on which reading prevails, because this section claims no continuing office of either kind. It claims that the sealing term the Qur'an actually uses falls on the giving of revelation, and that the text nowhere seals the receiving, carrying,

and living of what was given. Read at its widest, the seal closes both offices entirely and the argument below stands unchanged; read at its narrowest, it closes one and says nothing of the other, and the argument below still does not reach for what the silence leaves. The silence is not a second seal and it is not a license, and a reader who takes it for the second has taken from this study something it declines to give.

A word is owed on grade before the argument proceeds, since the change is real. The sections to this point have been descriptive: the text says a thing, the root carries a sense, the registers populate as they populate, and the reader can check every claim against the Arabic. What follows is constructive. It reasons from what the portrait has shown to what the portrait holds open, and the verses it will cite for continuing guidance are general in their address rather than statements about the period after prophecy. The reasoning is offered as reasoning and the reader is asked to weigh it as such. It is not put forward at the grade of the philology that precedes it, and nothing in the preceding sections depends on it.

The reaching of God's guidance to the living the Qur'an keeps wholly open. The community is charged to call to the good and to forbid the wrong (3:104). The one who was dead and was given a light walks by it among the people (6:122). And a party of the believers is to gain understanding in religion and then to warn their own people on returning to them (9:122), a warning office assigned in plain words to those who are not messengers. These are offices of guidance, and the text names them without the word *rasūl*. The point must be made with verses that carry it and not with verses that do not: the summons of 8:24 is to respond "to God and to the Messenger," *wa-li-l-rasūl*, and it therefore belongs on the other side of this ledger, as a call issued through the messenger rather than an office named apart from him. The recited Word itself, sent down as a guidance for mankind (2:185), is carried and recited and borne from one generation to the next, and the one who bears it bears what is not his own. The Qur'an frames even its highest bearer in exactly this way: the Prophet ﷺ is told to say that he is only a man to whom it is revealed (18:110), and it is said of him that his speech is "nothing but a revelation revealed" (53:4) and that upon him lies only the conveyance (5:99; 24:54), the first in his own mouth by the imperative and the others declared of him. The bearer bears a message whose origin is God. The giving of a new revelation is what the seal addresses; the carrying of what has been given is what continues. The seal was set upon the source, never upon the stream.

Behind this openness stands something the Qur'an places before every prophet. It speaks of an original disposition upon which God shaped mankind, the *fiṭra* (30:30), and of a covenant taken before time, when He drew from the children of Adam the acknowledgment of their Lord, "Am I not your Lord? They said, Yes" (7:172). The pattern toward which the prophets call is thus prior to them. They are not its authors but its clearest bearers, and the text is explicit that they are set to be followed and not admired from a distance: in the Messenger ﷺ there is a beautiful example for whoever hopes in God and the Last Day (33:21), as there was a beautiful example in Abraham and those

with him (60:4). An example stands at the head of a road. He does not lie across it as a wall. And because, as the synthesis has shown, the summit of this prophet is servanthood, the imitation the text invites is the imitation of a servant, a station withheld from no one. The seal closes the office of revelation; it does not close the road of resemblance, the labor of the servant to grow toward the pattern the prophets carried. To revere the Prophet ﷺ and to walk toward him are not two motions but one.

The road the prophets walked ran through trial, and the Qur'an does not conceal that they walked it as men. It says plainly that there was no messenger and no prophet before whom, when he *tamannā*, Satan did not cast something into his *umniyya*, and that God then annuls what Satan casts and makes His verses firm (22:52). The verb is disputed and the dispute should be recorded rather than settled by silence: from the root *m-n-y* it carries both wishing and reciting, the lexica attest the reciting sense, and of the four translations checked for this study one takes it so while three render it as desiring. The reading followed here is the reciting sense, because the object *umniyya* is what Satan casts into and what God then annuls, and it is verses, *āyāt*, that the same sentence says God makes firm. A reader who takes the wishing sense loses the application to recitation and keeps the substance that matters below, that the suggestion was real and the purifying was God's. The suggestion was real; the purifying was God's. The servant who reads this is not taught that nearness is the absence of the whisper but that it is the whisper overcome, and that the strength to overcome is granted from above. The prophets are exemplary not because temptation never reached them but because they were carried through it, and the same help is the hope held out to the one who follows.

And the trials read in the third movement give that following its shape. In each of them the Prophet ﷺ met his crisis not by a power in himself but by a turning to God for what he could not supply: slandered, he awaited the vindication and did not force it; questioned past the edge of his knowledge, he confessed the limit; tempted to bend the word, he was held firm from above; harmed as other men are harmed, he was given a refuge to recite. To walk the road of the servant is to learn that turning, not a power to wield but a dependence to keep. And the path is shown open at its plainest in the last of those trials, for the refuge that was the Prophet's ﷺ own protection was placed in his mouth and in every believer's alike, the two closing sūras a word given to all who will say it. The same recitation that was his armor is the reader's, and there is no plainer proof that the road of the servant was left open than that its very protection is a verse anyone may recite.

Read in this way, the resistance the second movement diagnosed loses its ground. The envy that refused the prophet at every turn, the angel's pride and the clansman's and the heir's, and that sundered the one community into sects, wears two faces in the single heart. One denies the prophet outright. The other sets him so far beyond reach that to follow him is quietly excused, and an idol is raised where an example was meant to stand. Both are answered at once when the prophet is received as what he was sent to be, a servant whose nearness

is, by God's design, a road and not a fence. Envy finds no footing against a door held open; it turns toward love, and the love refuses every tribal narrowing, for the text refuses it first. Of the messengers the believers say, "we make no distinction between any of them" (2:285); of mankind God says that the most honored before Him is the most mindful of Him, and not the nearest by birth or banner (49:13). This is the healing of the sundering, the one community restored not by erasing its prophets but by walking toward the pattern they set, the same undivided line to which the People of the Book were called. The Prophet ﷺ is honored most not by walling his station but by walking toward it.

And the road is to be walked with understanding, not borne in the dark. The Qur'an reproaches those who were entrusted with the Book and then carried it without grasping it, likening them to a donkey that carries volumes (62:5), and it commands the contrary, asking whether they will not ponder the Qur'an (47:24) and naming itself a blessed Book sent down that its verses might be pondered (38:29). The depth it asks to be pondered is a depth in what is given, not a second text behind the first, and the way into it is opened by reflection rather than reserved to a class. The verse that names an Outer and an Inner, "He is the First and the Last, the Outer and the Inner" (57:3), predicates those of God and not of the Book, and it is not evidence for a hidden stratum of scripture; it is cited here only for the pairing it holds, that an outer and an inner are not rivals in the Qur'an's own way of speaking, and the commands to ponder carry the point on their own. Belief received from others is a beginning. It was never meant to be the end of the road.

So the seal, read with the same care the rest of this study has used, gives not a smaller Prophet ﷺ but a nearer one. The office of revelation is closed and the line of the prophets sealed and ratified; the carriage of God's guidance continues under names that are not *rasūl*; the road of the servant stays open to whoever will walk it, the prophets foremost upon it and beckoning rather than barring. And what lies past the seen remains where the text leaves it, with God, who holds the keys of the unseen, which "none knows but He" (6:59), and who discloses of that unseen "to none but a messenger He has approved" (72:26-27), the exception standing in the second verse and not the first. The hope this leaves the reader is the truest the portrait affords: not a distant figure to be guarded from a safe remove, but the first of the servants on a road that was never closed, and a calling, open to all, to walk it.

25. Conclusion

The Qur'an's portrait of the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ holds exaltation and accountability together by design. He is named with the highest titles the text affords, the seal of the prophets and the mercy to the worlds, blessed by God and the angels and called by names that are God's own, and he is addressed, in the same scripture and often in the same passage, as a mortal who will die, who does not know the unseen, who holds no power over outcomes, who is reproved for particular acts within his own household, and who is commanded to seek forgiveness. Set beside the earlier prophets, he is given no staff

and no clay made to breathe, but the recited Word, a universal scope, and the office of the seal that confirms and completes their line. Read across the themes of his portrait, the contest brought against it, and the trials that met him, from his naming to the refuge he was given to recite, the portrait does not fracture. It coheres around a single conception.

That conception has two faces, which are finally one. The Prophet ﷺ is the maximal locus of divine action and never its autonomous source; his greatness is the greatness of perfect reception and faithful conveyance, and it reaches its height where his very act is named the act of God, where his wish is answered by the turning of the qibla, and where the prophets before him point toward him as the seal that ratifies and completes their succession. And his accountability, far from competing with his rank, is the mechanism of it, on the model of the Adam whom the Qur'an shows chosen by his Lord after he had erred and turned back (20:121-122). The most-praised servant is the one whose every excellence points beyond himself to its Giver, and who, at the height of his triumph, turns to seek forgiveness. In the Qur'anic portraiture, the honor and the dependence are the same fact, named from every side the text commands. And because that greatness is a servant's greatness, the portrait closes not as a wall but as an invitation: the seal that ends the descent of revelation leaves open the road of the servant the prophets walked, sets them at its head as the example the believer is bidden to follow, and offers the reader not a figure to be admired from afar but the first upon a path that was never closed. And that the path was never closed the text seals at its plainest in the end, when the Prophet's ﷺ own refuge against the harms that reach all men was given to every believer alike as a word to recite.

Sources

The primary and governing source of this study is the Qur'an itself, cited throughout by sūra number and verse. The reading rests on the Arabic text and on the consonantal roots of its key terms, with a given term illuminated where necessary by the same root's use in other verses, and the interpretive frame is drawn from the Qur'an's own usage rather than from external commentary.

English wording was checked against the following standard translations, consulted for phrasing only. The renderings given in this study are the author's own, prepared directly from the Arabic.

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Appendix A. Note on Transliteration and Conventions

Transliteration follows a light academic scheme. Long vowels are marked ā, ī, ū. The emphatic and other distinguished consonants are marked with a dot below: ḥ, ṣ, ṭ, ḏ, ḏ. The letter ‘ayn is represented by ‘ and the hamza by ʾ. Roots are given as their bare consonants separated by hyphens, for example *h-m-d*, and are read directly from the Arabic; where the sense of a term in a given verse is not plain, the same root is followed through its other occurrences in the text to recover the meaning, a procedure used most fully for *kh-t-m* in Section 10. Qur’anic citations give the sūra number followed by the verse number or range, as 33:40 or 80:1-10; sūra names are given in transliteration at first mention within each table. The honorific ﷺ follows the name and titles of the Prophet Muhammad in keeping with established usage, and rests on the Qur’an’s own statement that God and the angels invoke blessing upon him (33:56). English renderings of the verses are the author’s own, prepared directly from the Arabic text and checked for phrasing against the standard translations listed in the Sources.

Appendix B. Glossary of Principal Roots

The roots below carry the paper’s key terms. Each entry gives first the sense the word bears in current and Qur’anic usage, and then, where the skeleton preserves it, the raw image buried in the three consonants, the concrete and often bodily thing the root meant before it was lifted into abstraction. The method is excavation rather than loose etymology: the one consonantal skeleton is followed across its derived words to recover the single picture beneath them, read directly from the Arabic and without the later doctrinal smoothing. The order is the Arabic alphabet.

ʾ-dh-n: to permit, to give leave; *idhn*, the divine leave by which the prophets’ signs are worked, “by God’s leave” (3:49). The skeleton is the ear (*udhun*); to give leave is to incline the ear and let a thing through, permission as a hearing granted.

ʾ-f-k: to lie, to slander; *ifk*, the great slander against the household (24:11). The raw sense is to turn a thing over and invert it; the *mu’tafikāt* are the overturned cities (53:53), and the lie is truth tipped upside down, the world stood on its head.

ʾ-j-r: a wage, a reward; *ajr*, the recompense a messenger does not ask (26:109). Beneath it, to set and splint a broken bone (the *ajr* of a fracture); the wage is the mending that restores, payment as repair.

ʾ-m-r: to command, an affair, the matter in hand; *amr*, “not for you is any part of the matter” (3:128), and the *rūḥ min amrinā* of the revelation (42:52). The skeleton is the ordering word and the affair it orders, command and outcome named by one root; what is withheld from the Prophet ﷺ at Uḥud is not the acting but the disposing.

ʾ-w-l: priority, the first, the greater claim; *awlā*, “the Prophet ﷺ is closer to the believers than themselves” (33:6). The root is return, the

coming back to an origin (*awl*); what is first is what one returns to, and the greater claim is the claim of the source.

ʾ-y-y: a sign, a mark, a token; *āya*, at once a miracle and a verse of scripture (2:118). The skeleton is the bare mark left for recognition, the trace by which a thing is known; wonder and verse are named alike as marks set for the eye that reads.

b-d-ʿ: to originate without precedent; *bidʿ*, “I am no new thing among the messengers” (46:9), and *al-Badīʿ*, the Originator. The raw image is the first sinking of a well never dug before, to bring forth where nothing of the kind has stood; origination is the breaking of new ground.

b-d-l: to change, to exchange; *baddala*, the altering of the word entrusted (2:59). The skeleton is substitution, one thing set in the place of another, the swap that leaves the slot filled but the content replaced.

b-gh-y: to seek wrongfully, to overstep, insolent envy; *baghy*, read in this study as the single root of rejection and schism (2:213; 42:14). Beneath it lies the wound that swells and festers past its bound (*baghā l-jurḥ*) and the one who sells the body (*baghiyy*); envy here is a swelling that breaks its own skin, a seeking that will not keep its bound.

b-h-l: to invoke earnestly, to imprecate; *ibtihāl*, the mutual cursing proposed at Najran (3:61). The raw sense is to leave unrestrained, the she-camel turned loose with her udder unbound (*bahl*); to imprecate is to loose the matter wholly to God, tether cut, and let His judgment fall.

b-l-gh: to reach, to convey, to attain; *balāgh*, “upon the messenger lies only the conveyance” (5:99). The skeleton is arrival at a destination and the coming of age (*bulūgh*); the bearer’s whole task is to carry the thing the full distance and set it down intact.

b-r-ʾ: to be clear of, to absolve, to create by separating; *baraʾa*, “they are absolved of what they say” (24:26), and *al-Bārī*, the Maker. The raw image is recovery from sickness (*burʾ*) and the cutting-free of one thing from another; to absolve is to be made clean of a thing, and to create is to part the made from the unmade.

b-sh-r: skin, flesh, the human, and to bring good news; *bashar*, the human being (18:110), and *bashīr*, the herald of glad tidings. The buried picture is the outer skin itself (*basharab*); good news is named from the face, the skin that brightens and shows the tidings before the mouth speaks.

b-y-n: to be clear, to make plain, to separate; *bayyina*, the clear proof (2:118), and *mubīn*, the manifest. The skeleton is the gap between two things (*bayn*), the distance that lets each be seen apart; to make plain is to open that space so the eye can tell one from another.

t-b-ʿ: to follow; *ittabaʾa*, “I follow only what is revealed to me” (46:9). The raw sense is to walk in another’s tracks, to come behind in the same prints; to follow the revelation is to set one’s feet where it has stepped.

t-l-w: to recite, and to follow; *tilāwa*, the recitation of the signs (2:252). The skeleton is one thing close on the heel of another; reciting is following the text word after word, each syllable trailing the last, so that to recite and to follow are one motion.

t-w-b: to turn back, to return; *tawba*, the repentance the Prophet ﷺ is commanded toward (110:3), and *al-Tawwāb*, the ever-relenting. The raw image is the bodily turn, the swing of the whole frame back toward what it left; repentance is a reversal of the feet, and God's relenting is His turning back toward the one who turns.

th-b-t: to be fixed, to stand firm; *tathbīt*, “had We not made you firm, you would have nearly inclined” (17:74). The skeleton is the rooted and the planted, a stake driven and held; firmness is not the absence of the pull but the root that does not give when pulled.

j-b-r: to force, to set by force, to compel; *jabbār*, “you are not over them a compeller” (50:45), and *al-Jabbār*. The raw image is the splinting of a broken bone (*jabara l-‘azm*), the limb forced straight and held; compulsion in the skeleton is a setting-by-force, and the Prophet ﷺ is told he is not to set men so.

j-d-l: to dispute, to argue; *jidāl*, and *al-Mujādila*, the sūra of the woman who argued (58:1). The raw sense is the tight twisting of a rope (*jadīl*), strand wound hard against strand; argument is a wrestling of twisted cords, each pulling the braid its own way.

j-h-r: to be open, loud, manifest; *jahra*, “show us God openly” (2:55). The skeleton is the plain and the exposed, the thing said aloud and seen in full light; to demand God *jabratan* is to demand Him brought out into the open eye.

j-n-n: the hidden, the covered; *jinn*, the concealed beings (72:1). The root is concealment itself. The same three letters give *janna*, to veil in darkness; *jannab*, the garden whose leaves hide its floor; *janīn*, the embryo curtained in the womb; and *majnūn*, the reason screened from itself. One picture under them all: what is covered from sight.

h-f-z: to guard, to keep, to preserve; *ḥafīẓ*, “We have not sent you as a keeper over them” (42:48; 6:107). The skeleton is the watchful holding of a thing intact against loss; the keeper is one charged with an outcome, and it is the charge, not the caring, that is lifted from him.

h-k-m: to judge, to govern, to be wise; *ḥukm*, the judgment that is God's in the Torah (5:43), and *ḥakīm*, the wise. The raw image is the bridle (*ḥakama*) that curbs the horse; to judge is to rein in, and wisdom is the restraint that holds chaos to a course.

h-m-d: to praise, to commend; *Muḥammad*, the much-praised, and *Aḥmad*, and *al-Ḥamid*. The skeleton is praise rendered as due, not flattery but the acknowledgment owed; the Prophet's ﷺ name is its passive form, the one praise comes to, never its source.

h-s-d: to envy; *ḥasad*, the envier's evil sought refuge from (113:5). The raw sense is a gnawing, an itch or mange that eats inward; envy in the skeleton is a thing that consumes the one who holds it from within.

kh-l-q: to create, and disposition, nature; *khuluq*, the “magnificent character” of 68:4, and *ikhṭilāq*, the fabrication charged against the revelation (38:7). The buried image is the measuring and cutting of leather to a proportion (*khalaqa l-adīm*); to create is to fashion by exact measure, and to fabricate a lie is the same craft turned to a false cut.

kh-t-m: to seal, to stamp, to finish; *khātam*, set upon the Prophet ﷺ in 33:40. The root occurs eight times and the census divides by form. The five verbal uses all shut: hearts and hearing sealed against reception (2:7; 6:46; 45:23), mouths sealed in final testimony (36:65), and the conditional seal upon the Prophet's ﷺ own heart (42:24). The three nominal uses carry the certifying sense: the sealed wine and its finish, “whose seal is musk” (83:25-26), and *khātam* itself. The raw image is the signet pressed into clay or wax, the ring that at once closes a thing and stamps it as genuine; the verb ends and fixes, and the noun ends, authenticates, and completes in one act.

kh-ṣ-m: to contend at law, an adversary; *khaṣīm*, “he is a manifest adversary” (16:4). The skeleton is the litigant, the one who stands against you in dispute; the same word names the disputant and the dispute, the contention and the one who carries it.

d-‘-w: to call, to summon, to claim; *da‘īyy*, the adopted son, the one called to a father not his own (33:5), and the offices of guidance that “call to the good.” The raw sense is the raised voice that summons; the adopted son is a sonship by calling-out rather than by blood, a name conferred by the voice.

dh-k-r: to remember, to mention; *dhikr*, the reminder the bearers carry. The skeleton holds also the male (*dhakar*) and the sharp point; remembrance is the keen edge of the mind that pierces back to what was, and mention the bringing of it again to the tongue.

dh-n-b: an offense, a fault; *dhanb*, the fault the Prophet ﷺ is told to seek covering for (40:55). The raw image is the tail (*dhanab*), the part that trails behind; a fault is what drags after the deed, the consequence following at the heel like a tail.

r-‘-f: tender kindness, pity; *ra‘ūf*, a divine name applied to the Prophet (9:128) ﷺ. The skeleton is the softest pity, the tenderness that flinches at another's pain; it is the gentlest grade of mercy, compassion at its most yielding.

r-j-l: a man, the adult male; *rajul*, “two men of those who feared God” (5:23). The raw image is the foot and the leg (*rijl*); the man is named the one who stands and goes on his own legs, manhood as the upright gait.

r-h-m: the womb, mercy; *rahma* and *rahīm*, and *al-Raḥmān* and *al-Raḥīm*. The buried picture is the womb (*rahim*) itself; mercy in the skeleton is womb-feeling, the sheltering and feeding of the utterly dependent, named from the organ that holds and nourishes the unformed.

r-ḏ-w: to be content, to approve; *irtadā*, the messenger God “has approved” to whom alone the unseen is disclosed (72:27). The

skeleton is satisfaction, the settling of the self in consent; approval is the will at rest in a thing, wanting it as it is.

r-s-l: to send, to dispatch, to let flow; *rasūl*, the sent one. The skeleton is the loosing of a thing to go, a herd sent to water or hair let down loose (*irsāl*); the messenger is one released toward a destination by a sender, the sending never his own.

r-sh-d: right direction, sound judgment; *rushd*, the “right conduct” the jinn heard the recitation guide to (72:2). The raw image is holding to the true road and the maturity that can hold it (*rushd*, the coming of age); guidance here is the path kept and the judgment grown firm enough to keep it.

r-m-y: to throw, to cast; *ramā*, “you did not throw when you threw, but God threw” (8:17). The raw sense is the bodily hurl, the arm’s release of a stone or shaft; the verse takes the most physical of acts and names its force as God’s.

r-w-h: spirit, breath, wind; *rūḥ*, named of Jesus, “a Spirit from Him” (4:171), of the Holy Spirit, and of the revelation, “a Spirit of Our command” (42:52). The skeleton is moving air, breath and wind and the cool of relief (*rāḥa*); spirit in the root is the unseen breath that animates, known only by its motion.

z-w-j: a pair, a spouse, a yoke; *zawj*, the wife kept or released in the trial of the household (33:37). The raw image is the yoking of two, a pair coupled to pull together; a spouse is one of a matched two, joined to a single draught.

s-h-r: sorcery, enchantment; *siḥr*, the label “a manifest sorcerer” (10:2) and the bewitchment marked as the contested occasion of the refuge sūras. The raw sense is to turn a thing from its true nature to a false seeming, kin to *saḥar*, the turning-edge of night into dawn; magic in the skeleton is a diverting, the real bent into a counterfeit of itself.

s-l-m: peace, safety, surrender; *salm*, the peace to be inclined to “if they incline to it” (8:61), and *islām* and *salām*. The buried image is wholeness and soundness (*salima*, to be unhurt, entire); peace is the body intact, and to surrender is to hand oneself over whole into safekeeping.

s-ṭ-r: to rule lines, to write in rows, to dominate; *muṣayṭir*, “you are not over them a controller” (88:22). The raw image is the drawn line and the written row (*saṭr*); to dominate is to rule lines over another, to set them within margins one has drawn.

sh-ʿ-r: to perceive finely, hair, poetry; *shāʿir*, the “poet” the Prophet ﷺ was called (21:5). The skeleton is the hair (*shaʿr*) and the fine sensing it stands for (*shaʿara*, to feel acutely); the poet is named the one of hair-fine perception, and the charge of poetry sets mere fine feeling against revealed knowledge.

sh-f-ʿ: to pair, to make even, to intercede; *shafāʿa*, the intercession that holds only “by His leave” (2:255). The raw image is the even number (*shafʿ*) against the odd, the adding of a second to a one; to intercede is to come alongside as a second, pairing one’s plea to another’s need.

sh-r-h: to open, to expand, to lay open; *sharaha*, “did We not expand for you your breast” (94:1). The raw sense is to slit and splay wide, to lay a thing open as one opens meat to the bone; the expansion of the breast is a cutting-wide of the inner space to receive.

sh-y-ʿ: to will, to want; *mashīʿa*, the will of God excepted into every plan, “except that God wills” (18:24). The skeleton is bare volition, the wanting that brings a thing toward being; the correction of the Prophet’s ﷺ promise binds his every “I will” beneath this larger willing.

sh-y-ʿ: to spread, to follow in a party; *shiyaʿ*, the “sects” into which the one religion was cut (6:65). The raw image is diffusion and accompaniment, a thing spread abroad and a band that walks together; a sect is a following spread off on its own line, splinter and company at once.

ṣ-d-q: to be true, to confirm; *muṣaddiq*, the Qur’an “confirming what was before it” (3:3). The skeleton joins truth and hardness; the true is the solid that bears weight, and to confirm is to stand under what came before and hold it up.

ḍ-y-q: to be narrow, constricted; *ḍāqa*, the breast that “tightens” under denial (11:12). The raw image is the strait and the pinched, space closing in until it grips; distress in the skeleton is room running out, the chest narrowed to a clench.

ṭ-ʿ-m: to taste, to eat, food; *ṭaʿām*, the objection that the messenger “eats food and walks the markets” (25:7). The skeleton is the bare act of tasting and the food tasted; the adversaries press it as proof of mere creatureliness, the mouth that must be fed.

z-h-r: the back, to appear, midday; *zihār*, the old repudiation that likened the wife to “the back of the mother” (58:2). The raw image is the back (*zahr*), the surface turned and shown and the strength that bears a load; the same root gives the manifest (*zāhir*) and the noon (*zubr*), the outer face fully lit.

ʿ-b-d: to serve, to worship; *ʿabd*, the servant, the title chosen for the Prophet ﷺ at the summit of the ascent (17:1). The raw image is the smoothed and trodden path (*ṭariq muʿabbad*), ground made firm by being walked; the servant is one shaped to a road, level under the foot of his Lord.

ʿ-b-s: to frown, to scowl; *ʿabasa*, “he frowned and turned away” (80:1). The skeleton is the knit brow itself, the face drawn tight in displeasure; the sūra opens on the bare physical act, the muscles of the face indicted before the deed is named.

ʿ-m-r: to live long, to inhabit, to build; *ʿumr*, the lifespan by which God swears and against which a life is weighed. The raw image is the filling of a place with life (*ʿimāra*, to cultivate and people a land); a lifespan is a span inhabited, the years filled as one fills a house.

ʿ-ṣ-m: to grasp, to hold fast, to protect; the verb in “God will protect you from the people” (5:67). The buried picture is the handhold seized and the rope clung to (*iṭṭasama bi-*, to grip fast); protection in the skeleton is not a wall but a grip, the firm hold that keeps one from falling.

‘-w-dh: to seek refuge, to take shelter; *isti’ādha*, and the *mu’awwidhatān*, the two sūras of refuge (113-114). The raw sense is to cling to a thing for safety, to fasten oneself to a protector; to seek refuge is to grip God as a frightened creature grips what shelters it.

gh-f-r: to cover, to forgive; *istighfār*, the seeking of forgiveness commanded at the summit (110:3), and *al-Ghafūr*. The raw image is the covering-over, kin to the *mighfār*, the helmet that covers the head; forgiveness in the skeleton is a covering laid over the fault, hidden from sight rather than unmade.

gh-y-b: the hidden, the absent; *ghayb*, the unseen whose keys are God’s alone (6:59). The skeleton is absence from sight, what has sunk below the horizon (*ghābat al-shams*, the sun set); the unseen is the withdrawn, present but past the edge of the eye.

f-r-q: to split, to part, to distinguish; *furqa*, the “division” of the one community (42:14), and *al-Furqān*, the criterion. The raw image is the cleaving of a thing in two, the parting of the sea and the parting-line of the hair (*farq*); to distinguish is to cut between, and schism is the cut turned upon the body it should have served.

f-r-y: to fabricate, to invent falsely; *iftirā’*, the charge of forging a lie against God (25:4; 46:8); at 69:44 the same charge is carried by *taqawwala*, from *q-w-l*. The raw sense is the cutting of leather to shape (*farā l-adīm*); fabrication is a real craft of cutting and joining, but a thing cut to a false pattern and passed as given.

f-t-h: to open, to seek victory; *istiftāh*, the People of the Book who “had prayed for victory” by him (2:89), and *al-Fattāh*. The raw image is the opening of a closed door and the taking of a closed city; victory in the skeleton is an opening, the shut thing forced wide.

f-t-n: trial, temptation; *fitna*, the danger the firmness guarded against (17:73). The buried picture is the smelting of gold in fire to part it from its dross (*fatana l-dhahab*); a trial is an assaying by burning, the heat that proves what a thing is made of.

f-ḍ-l: to exceed, to favor, to grant surplus; *faddala*, “We favored some of the prophets above others” (2:253). The skeleton is the overplus, the remainder above the measure (*faddl*, what exceeds need); favor is a surplus poured beyond the due, more given than was owed.

q-b-l: to face, to turn toward, to accept; *qibla*, the direction of prayer turned for him (2:144). The raw image is the front and the facing (*qubul*); to accept is to turn the face toward, and the qibla is the chosen face the whole body fronts in prayer.

q-r-b: to be near; *qurbā*, kinship (42:23), and *qurbān*, the offering brought near (5:27). The skeleton is approach, the closing of distance; kinship is nearness of blood and an offering a nearness sought by gift. The vision’s “two bows’ length” (53:9) does not belong here: *qāba* is from *q-w-b*, a measure of span, and the nearness in that passage is carried by *danā* and *adnā*, from *d-n-w*.

q-w-m: to stand, to rise; *maqām*, the “praised station” of the Prophet (17:79) ﷺ. The raw image is the upright posture, the rising to one’s feet; a station is a standing-place, a rank named for where one stands and how high.

q-ṭ-‘: to cut, to sever; *taqaṭṭu’*, the religion “cut into pieces” among them (21:93). The raw sense is the clean severing, a thing chopped through; the schism is named the dismemberment of one body, cut into parts that no longer hold.

k-f-l: to take charge of, a portion, a double share; *kifl*, “a portion” of the burden or the reward (4:85). The raw image is the part folded back on itself, a double fold (*kifl*); a portion is a fold of the whole assigned to one, charge and share at once.

k-l-m: to speak, a word, a wound; *kalima*, the Word predicated of Jesus (4:171), and *kalām*, the speech of God. The buried picture is the wound (*kalm*) that breaks a surface; a word in the skeleton is a thing that cuts and marks, speech that leaves an incision on the air and the ear.

k-th-r: to be much, to abound; *kawthar*, the “abundance” granted against the taunt of being cut off (108:1). The skeleton is sheer multitude, number past counting; the gift is named the overflowing, set exactly against the enemy’s charge of barrenness.

m-w-t: death, stillness; *mawt*, “you will die and they will die” (39:30). The skeleton is the going-still, the cessation of motion and breath; death in the root is the stop, the frame fallen quiet, and the Prophet ﷺ is held under it with all that breathe.

n-b-’: to announce, to bring weighty news; *nabī*, the prophet, and by the alternate root *n-b-w*, to be raised high. The raw image is the report of consequence carried from afar (*naba’*, grave tidings); the prophet is the bearer of the weighty announcement, or the one raised up to bear it.

n-dh-r: to warn, to vow; *nadhīr*, the warner (35:24). The skeleton is the cry of alarm raised before a coming harm and the binding of a vow; to warn is to give notice of what advances, the voice thrown ahead of the danger.

n-f-q: to dissemble, to spend, a tunnel; *munāfiq*, the hypocrite hidden from the Prophet’s ﷺ sight (9:101), and *nifāq*. The buried image is the jerboa’s burrow with a second hidden mouth (*nāfiqā’*), the escape-hole kept covered until it bolts; the hypocrite is the creature that shows one entrance and keeps another to flee through.

n-ṣ-r: to help against an enemy, to defend, to give victory; *intiṣār*, the believing poets who “defend themselves after they were wronged” (26:227), and *naṣr*. The raw image holds also the rain that revives a dead land; help in the skeleton is a rescue sent down, aid that comes to the hard-pressed from beyond their own strength.

h-d-y: to guide, to lead the way; *hadā* and *hudā*, the guidance the Qur’an keeps wholly open (2:185). The raw image is leading along a road and the gift offered with the right hand (*hadiyya*); guidance is a leading-forward and a thing given, the way shown and the hand held out on it.

w-d-d: to love, to feel affection; *mawadda*, the “affection of kinship” asked as the only wage (42:23), and *al-Wadūd*. The skeleton is settled tender love, the wishing-well that holds steady; it is affection as a fixed disposition, not the flare but the constant warmth.

w-s-w-s: to whisper, to insinuate; *waswās*, the “slinking whisperer” sought refuge from (114:4). The word is its own sound, a low hidden hiss repeated, the rustle of a garment or the chink of ornaments; temptation in the skeleton is named by its noise, the faint susurrus at the edge of hearing.

w-t-n: the aorta, the life-vein; *watīn*, the great vessel the false prophet would have severed from him (69:46). The skeleton is the single cord

on which life hangs, the artery whose cutting empties the body; the image makes the threatened end exact and bodily.

y-d: the hand; *yad*, “the hand of God is over their hands” (48:10). The skeleton is the hand itself and, from it, power and a favor done (a *yad*, a benefaction given by hand); the hand in the root is agency made visible, the grip by which a thing is held and a gift is passed.